2 Collaboration, Interpersonal Communication, and Business Etiquette

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After studying this chapter, you will be able to

1. Describe the characteristics of effective teams, outline five steps for resolving team conflict, and offer advice on working in virtual teams.
2. Offer guidelines for collaborative communication, explain what it means to give constructive feedback, and identify major collaboration technologies.
3. List the key steps needed to ensure productive meetings.
4. Explain why listening is such a complex communication process, and describe three steps to becoming a better listener.
5. Explain the importance of nonverbal communication, and identify six major categories of nonverbal expression.
6. Explain the importance of business etiquette, and identify five key areas in which good etiquette is essential.

COMMUNICATION CLOSE-UP AT OpenText

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What makes a good manager? Many seem to think that effective management skills are suddenly instilled in people somewhere along the journey up the corporate ladder and that reaching the top gives you the opportunity to make your voice heard. However, the opposite is true, at least according to OpenText's CEO Mark Barrenechea, who believes that the value of listening cannot be understated. Making the effort to properly take stock of things and to listen to what employees and stakeholders are saying and asking for has certainly been a huge part of OpenText's successes since Barrenechea joined the company in 2012.

As an outside hire, Barrenechea hadn't worked at OpenText before when he was given the responsibility of managing it. Though he had accrued industry experience in Silicon Valley, he knew that he was by no means intimately familiar with the inner workings of the company. Upon joining, rather than impose his prior knowledge of the industry onto OpenText and enact strategies that might have worked at other technology firms, he instead recognized that he could learn the ropes best by listening to the employees he was now leading.

Since Barrenechea took the helm, OpenText's share price has increased by over 300 percent as of 2019. He transformed OpenText from a search company into an enterprise information management firm that lets businesses access and implement data in the most optimal way possible. Moreover, he listened to trends in the industry and recognized early on that automation and the cloud were where things were headed, so he made sure to expand OpenText's competencies to be ready for this.

OpenText have undertaken a healthy number of acquisitions since 2012, including entire businesses, such as cloud information management businesses Carbonite Inc. and Covisint. Despite a high frequency of acquisitions and varied markets of acquirees, OpenText is, in fact, one of the tech industry's rollup success stories. Again, it is the importance given to listening that kept post-merger performance from eroding these companies' value, for



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A philosophy of actively listening not only to customers and industry trends but also the people one works with has been central to OpenText's success.

each one marked a new area for Barrenechea to learn from and to implement strategies that don't unnecessarily try to fix what is already working well.

Beyond listening to employees, it is just as important to listen to external stakeholders, such as customers, and OpenText implements the CEO's philosophy in this regard as well. They therefore encourage a strong focus on the customers' experience and make efforts to collect customer insights and incorporate them into their everyday business decisions. A dedicated team analyzes data from key listening posts and the experience reports of customers and clients, then advises all the other divisions on how to make decisions that best reflect the needs of customers.[1]

Communicating Effectively in Teams

1 LEARNING OBJECTIVE
Describe the characteristics of effective teams, outline five steps for resolving team conflict, and offer advice on working in virtual teams.

OpenText's Mark Barrenechea (profiled in the chapter-opening Communication Close-Up) knows how essential listening is to every aspect of running a business. Listening is one of the interpersonal skills you will explore in this chapter, which starts with a look at communicating in teams.

Collaboration—working together to meet complex challenges—is a prime skill expected in a wide range of professions. No matter what career path you pursue, it's a virtual guarantee that you will need to collaborate in at least some of your work activities, and your communication skills will pay off handsomely in these interactions.

Collaboration, working together to solve complex problems, is an essential skill for workers in nearly every profession.

TYPES OF TEAMS

A **team** is a unit of two or more people who work toward a shared goal and, unlike other work groups, depend on one another to achieve that goal.[2] Teams are often at the core of **participative management**, the effort to involve employees in the company's decision-making.

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Participative management is the effort to involve employees in the company's decision-making.

Companies use a variety of team formats and sizes, with different degrees of structure and formality (see Table 2.1). The simplest team consists of two people assigned to collaborate on a task, with no more formality than the mandate to get the job done. At the other extreme, a team could have a hundred or more members and a formal management structure. Some teams have appointed leaders or managers, whereas others are self-managed.

A **cross-functional team** is one that includes people from more than one department or functional area within the company. Cross-functional teams are a powerful model for assembling talent because they can overcome the fixed organizational structure and unite people with different areas of expertise and responsibility. By helping to overcome the *silo effect*, where people within each functional area tend to view and perform their work within their own "silos," such teams can also serve as a vital communication network. For all their benefits, however, cross-functional teams must coordinate the work of people with different priorities and who formally report to managers in different parts of the company. Such teams are more vulnerable to internal conflict and competition than single-function teams and need strong leadership to be successful.[3]

A *cross-functional team* combines the efforts of people from multiple departments or functional areas across the company.

TABLE 2.1 Common Types of Business Teams

Type	Characteristics
Committee	A permanent team established to address recurring issues, such as corporate governance or workplace safety
Problem-solving	Team assembled to analyze a problem or issue, recommend a solution and, in some cases, implement the solution; sometimes referred to as a *task force*
Project	Team assembled to complete a specific project, such as a new product launch or installation of a new computer system
Creative	Similar to project teams but used in fields such as advertising and web design; combines the efforts of various creative professionals and may work on a series of projects together
Cross-functional	Pulls together people from across multiple departments or functional areas; the best way to tackle companywide issues or opportunities but can be challenging to manage

ADVANTAGES AND DISADVANTAGES OF TEAMS

Teams can provide businesses and individuals with a variety of benefits:[4]

The advantages of successful teamwork include pooling knowledge, taking advantage of diverse viewpoints, and increasing acceptance of solutions the team proposes.

- **More information and knowledge.** By pooling the experience of multiple individuals, a team has access to more information and experience.
- **Learning opportunities.** Teams that bring together people with various work specialties give members the chance to learn from each other.
- **Boldness.** People who might hesitate to take calculated risks on their own can be more willing to make bold moves as part of the team.
- **Accountability.** Participating in teams creates a built-in sense of accountability to others.
- **Trust building.** Working closely in teams helps people develop trust in their colleagues.
- **A broader range of viewpoints.** Diverse teams can bring a variety of perspectives that improve decision-making.
- **Buy-in for solutions the team creates.** Those who participate in making a decision are more likely to support it and encourage others to accept it.
- **Improved performance.** Effective teams can be better than top-performing individuals at solving complex problems.
- **A sense of community in good times and bad.** Being on a team helps individuals share in the celebration of successes and provides emotional support during challenging periods.

Although teamwork has many advantages, teams need to be aware of and work to counter the following potential disadvantages:

Teams need to avoid the negative impact of groupthink, hidden agendas, excessive costs, and employee overload.

- **Groupthink.** Like other social structures, business teams can generate tremendous pressure to conform. **Groupthink** occurs when peer pressure causes individual team members to withhold contrary opinions and to go along with decisions they don't really believe in. The consequences of groupthink can range from bland, unimaginative work to outright disasters.
- **Hidden agendas.** Some team members may have a **hidden agenda**—private, counterproductive motives, such as a desire to take control of the group, to undermine someone else on the team, or to pursue an incompatible goal.
- **Cost.** Aligning schedules, arranging meetings, and coordinating individual parts of a project can eat up a lot of time and money.
- **Overload.** Some companies have embraced collaborative work approaches to such an extent that they are overloading employees with team assignments.[5]

ETHICS DETECTIVE

How Did "We" Turn into "I"?

You are employed in the marketing department of a multinational company with its regional office in Oman. The head of the department called you to say that you and he will be working together on a new product launch. After that, he gave you certain guidelines and asked you to prepare a marketing plan. You spent almost two weeks and made a very comprehensive plan to market the product. Although your boss did not participate in the development phase, he appreciated your effort and asked you for a printed as well as an electronic copy. While you were preparing the final copy, you included the name of your boss along with your name as plan initiators. You gave him the hard copy as well as the electronic copy of the plan.

Three weeks later, your boss was out of the office when you received a phone call from the CEO's secretary, who asked you, as the number-two person in the department, to change some things in the plan. The secretary sent you the electronic copy of the marketing plan by email. You now see that your boss has removed your name from the document, and only his name is included as the plan initiator. You also noticed that the author name on the soft copy was changed. You are furious. You have spoken to one of your friends about this matter, but she could not give you any advice.

ANALYSIS

1. Is it ethical to remove a person's name from a document when that person has worked hard to produce that document? Is your boss's action correct?
2. What should your reaction be in this situation? Will you query your boss? Or will you bring the matter to the notice of the CEO's secretary while discussing the requested changes? What consequences will you face if you discuss this matter with the CEO's secretary?

CHARACTERISTICS OF EFFECTIVE TEAMS

The characteristics of effective teams include a shared purpose, a belief in the team's efforts, positive behavioral norms, and open and honest communication.

A wide variety of factors can account for team success:[6]

- A shared sense of purpose and compatible values
- A clear and challenging goal
- A belief in the value of the team's efforts
- A well-balanced mix of people who can provide the insights and skills needed to achieve the goal
- A size that aligns well with the team's responsibilities
- An environment of *psychological safety*, encouraging people to share information, propose unproven ideas, and express vulnerability without fear of repercussion
- A willingness to put the team's needs ahead of individual needs
- Open and honest communication

Notice how all these traits rely on communication, both in the information that is shared and in the way people interact with one another.

GROUP DYNAMICS

Group dynamics are the interactions and processes that take place in a team.

Norms are informal standards of conduct that members share and that guide member behavior.

The interactions and processes that take place among the members of a team are called **group dynamics**. Productive teams tend to develop clear **norms**, informal standards of conduct that members share and that guide member behavior. Group dynamics and norms are influenced by the roles team members assume and how the team evolves as it gets up to speed.

Team Roles

Team-maintenance roles focus on the interpersonal and social aspects of being on a team.

Task-oriented roles focus on work quality and productivity.

In addition to whatever functional skills they bring, members of a team can play a variety of helpful roles to ensure harmonious, productive work. **Team-maintenance roles** focus on the interpersonal and social aspects of being on a team, such as enforcing team norms, ensuring that everyone's voice is heard, encouraging participation, compromising, and mediating disputes.[7]

Task-oriented roles focus on work quality and productivity, getting the team's work done on time and on budget. They can include providing technical expertise, suggesting new ideas, integrating diverse ideas, exploring options, and keeping the team on schedule.[8]

As you can imagine, a team needs a healthy balance of both types of roles to be harmonious and successful. Of course, many people will take on more than one role, and someone may step into a role temporarily, such as mediating in a disagreement. Whenever you are working on a team, keep an eye out for ways you can help with any role, even if you aren't in a leadership position.

Stages of Team Development

The Tuckman model of group development usually includes five phases:
- Forming
- Storming
- Norming
- Performing
- Adjourning

Teams typically evolve through several phases on their way to becoming productive. Figure 2.1 shows the popular model proposed by Dr. Bruce Tuckman, which identifies four or five phases a new team goes through as it evolves:[9]

- **Forming.** The group comes together, and various members begin to establish themselves in specific roles. In some cases, one person is given the formal role of team leader, but in others an informal leader may emerge as the members establish their roles. If the group's goal hasn't already been defined, the team leader or the team members themselves will establish it.
- **Storming.** As team members begin to discuss their positions and become more assertive in establishing their roles, disagreements and uncertainties may arise. Much of the conflict may be constructive as team members share ideas for meeting the team's goals. However, if conflict threatens to get destructive, active conflict resolution might be necessary (see the next section). Everyone has responsibility for helping the team get through this turbulent phase as quickly as possible. Positive steps include appreciating the benefit of having diverse viewpoints, assuming that people are there to do good work, and giving everyone the opportunity to be heard.[10]

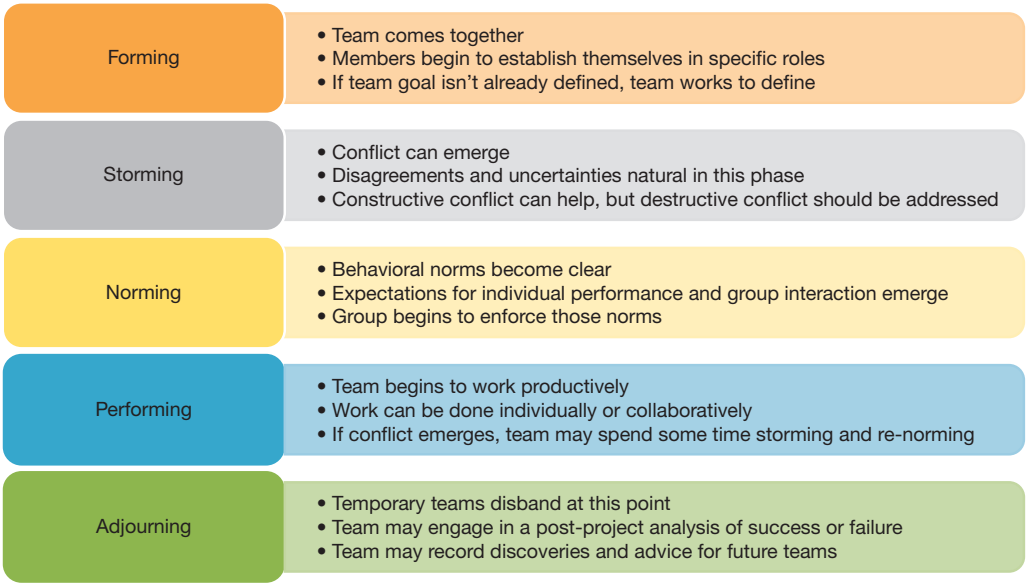


Figure 2.1 Phases of Team Development
Groups generally progress through several stages on their way to becoming productive and reaching their objectives.
Sources: Stephen P. Robbins and Mary Coulter, *Management*, 14th ed. (New York: Prentice Hall, 2018), 418–419; Denise Bonebright, "40 Years of Storming: A Historical Review of Tuckman's Model of Small Group Development," *Human Resource Development International* 29, 13, no. 1 (February 2010): 111–120.

- **Norming.** As conflicts are resolved, the team begins to take on a cohesive personality with clear behavioral norms, such as expectations of civil behavior and mutual dependability.
- **Performing.** With a cohesive, distinct personality and norms to guide behavior, the group is ready to perform its task. As the work progresses, new questions and conflicts may emerge, requiring the team to spend some time storming and re-norming again.
- **Adjourning.** When temporary teams accomplish their goal, the fifth and final step is to adjourn, or disband, the team. This phase may involve some post-project analysis in which members assess how well the team performed and compile advice for future teams.

Resolving Conflict in Teams

Even in the best of circumstances, people will occasionally disagree or rub each other the wrong way. And in dysfunctional environments with ineffective management, conflict can overwhelm normal business activities. Conflict can be a particular issue in team situations, where people are expected to prioritize team goals over their own individual interests. Conflict can arise for a variety of reasons, from competition for resources to disagreements over goals or work methods to personality differences.

Conflict in teams can be either constructive or destructive.

Constructive Versus Destructive Conflict Although the term *conflict* sounds negative, conflict isn't necessarily bad. It can be *constructive* if it forces important issues into the open, increases the involvement of team members, and generates creative ideas for solving a problem. Teamwork isn't always about happiness and harmony; even teams that have some interpersonal friction can excel with effective leadership and team players who are committed to strong results. As the teamwork experts Andy Boynton and Bill Fischer put it, "Virtuoso teams are not about getting polite results."[11]

In contrast, conflict is *destructive* if it diverts energy from more important issues, destroys the morale of teams or individual team members, or polarizes or divides the team.[12] Destructive conflict can lead to *win-lose* or *lose-lose* outcomes, in which one or both sides lose, to the detriment of the entire team. If you approach conflict with the idea that both sides can satisfy their goals to at least some extent (a *win-win* strategy), you can minimize losses for everyone.

Steps to Resolve Team Conflict When you encounter conflict in a team setting, follow these five steps to resolve it in a positive and constructive way:

As you move ahead with conflict resolution, start by examining your own potential contribution to the difficulties.

- **Decide if the conflict is worth addressing.** Resolving conflict takes time and energy and can temporarily disrupt activities and relationships. If the conflict is minor or will disappear on its own (such as when a temporary team disbands), it might make more sense to live with it.
- **Examine your own beliefs and behaviors.** If you are involved in a conflict that you want to resolve, examine your own stance before taking any action. You might be contributing to the conflict in ways you hadn't considered.
- **Identify where the conflict truly originates.** As you have probably experienced in your personal life, conflicts aren't always about what they *appear* to be about; the real difference may lie below the surface. For example, two team members might be arguing about work methods when their real conflict is deeper. They could have different cultural priorities, for instance, such as the importance of group harmony versus individual career success.
- **Establish common ground.** Figure out what everyone does agree on, and then use that foundation to build a solution. For example, if people disagree about the team's goals, dig deeper and find out if they agree about the company's overall goals and strategies. If they agree at that level, you can use that to launch a discussion about how to shape team goals that support the company's goals.

You have four choices for resolving conflict: avoidance, accommodation, compromise, or collaboration.

- **Choose a strategy for resolving the differences.** You have four basic choices here. (1) You can *avoid* the circumstances that create conflict, such as not assigning people who don't get along to the same tasks. Avoidance doesn't solve the underlying conflict, of course, but it can be the most efficient solution in some cases. (2) One side can choose to *accommodate* or sacrifice for the good of the organization or to maintain harmony in a relationship.[13] If two people disagree about the best way to approach a project, one might decide to accept and support the other's approach. (3) The two sides can choose to *compromise*, with both sides giving up something. Balanced compromise is one of the hallmarks of successful teams.[14] (4) Both sides can choose to *collaborate* on a new solution that satisfies everyone's needs and expectations—a win-win strategy. Collaboration in this sense can be a rewarding experience because it makes conditions better for everyone and gives a team or group the satisfaction of a shared accomplishment.

In any conflict situation, use active listening to understand the other party's position.

Whichever approach you take, practice and encourage respectful, calm communication. Everyone should choose their words and nonverbal gestures carefully to maintain focus on the problem at hand and to avoid further inflaming an already uncomfortable situation.[15] Use *active listening* (see page 96) to better understand what other people have to say.

VIRTUAL TEAMS

A *virtual team* is one in which members work in at least two different locations and rely on technology to communicate and collaborate.

A **virtual team** is one in which members work in at least two different locations and rely on technology to communicate and collaborate. Professionals in a wide variety of situations work in virtual teams, including telecommuting (working from home or other off-site locations), collaborating with colleagues in other offices, and working as independent contractors from remote locations.

Benefits and Challenges of Virtual Teamwork

Virtual teams can
- Pull together the best people for a task
- Take advantage of the benefits of telecommuting
- Increase engagement and productivity

Virtual teams can pull together the best people for a task, even if they work in different offices or different countries. Companies and employees can take advantage of the economic and personal benefits of telecommuting, and employees in geographically dispersed firms can reduce the amount of travel and the wear and tear it has on them and their families. In many cases, virtual teamwork is the only option available, such as when a company outsources its manufacturing to a firm in another country and teams made up of employees from both companies need to collaborate frequently.

Virtual teams can also yield some surprising benefits. Multiple studies show that successful virtual teams can be more effective, more engaged, and more productive than *co-located teams* (those in the same physical location).[16]

However, virtual teams present some challenges that must be addressed by any firm that uses them:

Key challenges of virtual teams include the tools used for collaboration and interpersonal communication issues.

- Virtual teams rely on technology, so any limitations in the tools (such as a videoconferencing system with poor video or audio connections) will affect team performance.
- Interpersonal communication is a constant challenge in virtual environments. Teams play an important social role in many cases, for instance, and long-distance team members can develop a sense of emotional isolation and the feeling of being "out of the loop."
- Distance and separation can foster an "us versus them" mentality between geographic factions in a team.[17]
- Virtual teams often miss out on the random interactions that co-located teams experience, such as members running into one another while getting coffee or otherwise crossing paths in the office.[18]

Tips for Success in Virtual Team Environments

To overcome the inherent limitations of virtual collaboration, follow these tips:

To maximize the success of virtual teams
- Keep them as small as possible
- Use the best technology available
- Clarify the purpose of every tool
- Keep remote members in the loop
- Don't rely solely on written communication

- **Keep teams as small as possible.** Even more so than with co-located teams, virtual teams can run into trouble if their size grows larger than 10 people or so.[19]
- **Use the best collaboration technology available.** The tools can range from something as simple as text messaging up to elaborate collaboration platforms (see page 83).
- **Clarify the purpose of each tool.** Make sure that each kind of communication, such as schedule updates, task assignments, and urgent messages, is conveyed via one designated channel.[20]
- **Take special care with isolated members.** If most of the team is co-located and a few members are remote, assign responsibility to someone in the local team for keeping remote members in the loop.
- **Don't rely solely on written communication.** Pick up the phone or initiate video chats to maintain a more personal connection.

Collaborating on Communication Efforts

Businesspeople are frequently expected to collaborate on communication projects. This section offers advice on how to approach collaborative work, tips on giving and receiving feedback, and an overview of the technologies available for collaboration.

2 LEARNING OBJECTIVE
Offer guidelines for collaborative communication, explain what it means to give constructive feedback, and identify major collaboration technologies.

COLLABORATION ARRANGEMENTS

Communicators can collaborate in a variety of ways, from simple writer-editor relationships to full collaboration.

Writer-Editor Relationships

The writer-editor relationship is a common form of collaborative communication.

The simplest collaboration is when one person reviews the work of another, which happens quite often in business. Although the collaboration is relatively simple, the task of reviewing someone else's work requires care and awareness. A writer may also ask two or more people to review a report or presentation. For instance, you might ask an engineer to review a brochure for technical accuracy and a marketing specialist to review it for brand messaging. Page 203 in Chapter 6 offers tips on reviewing someone else's writing.

Always clarify roles and expectations before starting any collaborative writing project.

Stepping up a level from that, one person can be asked to revise another's work, which takes the second person into the realm of co-creator. For reviewing or revising, it's vital to clarify expectations up front. If your draft is solid but just needs technical verification, for example, you don't want your technical reviewer to rewrite it for style. If you're asking

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someone for a general review, a good approach for many situations is to give both parties complete freedom: The reviewer/editor is free to comment on and suggest changes to anything, and the writer is free to accept or reject each of those inputs. Change-tracking features in word-processing software make it easy to accept or reject changes one by one.

If you're asking someone to revise a draft you've written, explain your objectives for the piece, including the audience you want to reach and the message you intend to share. At that point, you need to release "emotional ownership" of the piece and allow your collaborator to revise and rebuild it as he or she sees fit.

Full Collaboration

Full collaboration involves working together from planning the message to final production. This sort of partnership can bring together a diverse range of talents, insights, and experiences, not to mention extra minds and hands to get the work done.

Most communication tasks lend themselves to collaboration, but think carefully before doing the actual writing as a team; group writing can be valuable but it can also be slow and frustrating.

Collaboration offers lots of potential, but it must be planned and managed thoughtfully to realize these benefits. Most of the tasks involved in creating communication pieces lend themselves quite nicely to team effort, but think carefully before composing as a group—that is, doing the actual writing itself. Composing as a group isn't always productive because writing is a highly individualized activity that requires thought and reflection, and most ideas can be expressed effectively in more than one way. Various people can have equally valid ways to express something and spend time trying to convince the group to use their versions. The result could be a slower process that doesn't produce meaningfully better results. Group writing can be done, and it can be a great way for an experienced writer to mentor a colleague, but recognize that it can be slow and occasionally frustrating.

You may find times when it is helpful to involve multiple writers, such as when you're struggling to express an idea clearly. However, chances are you'll find it more efficient to plan, research, and outline together but assign the task of writing to one person or divide larger projects among multiple writers.

If you divide the writing tasks, make sure you have a clear and complete outline first.

If you decide to divide the writing among two or more people, outline the entire document or presentation in detail first. This way, each writer knows exactly how his or her assigned section fits in the overall flow, which minimizes gaps and overlaps and reduces the work needed to "stitch" the pieces together into a cohesive whole. When the pieces are ready, assign one person to do a final revision pass to ensure a consistent style.

To ensure success with collaborative communication projects
- Agree on the goals first
- Map out how the work will be done
- Take advantage of each person's strongest skills
- Establish frequent checkpoints
- Accept different writing styles

However you structure a project, follow these tips:

- Make sure the project goals are clear and agreed on.
- Map out how the work will be done, including who will take the lead on each task and which systems and tools will be used.
- Structure the assignments so that each person can lend his or her greatest strengths to the effort.
- Establish frequent checkpoints so the team can verify that each task is coming along as expected and adjust plans if needed.
- Appreciate that people have different writing styles. If something works, support it, even if it's not the way you would say it.

GIVING—AND RESPONDING TO—CONSTRUCTIVE FEEDBACK

Constructive feedback focuses on the process and outcomes of communication, not on the people involved.

Collaborative communication often involves giving and receiving feedback about writing efforts. **Constructive feedback**, sometimes called *constructive criticism*, focuses on the process and outcomes of communication, not on the people involved (see Table 2.2).

When you receive constructive feedback on your writing, keep your emotions in check and view it as an opportunity to improve.

When you receive constructive feedback, resist the urge to defend your work or deny the validity of the feedback. Remaining open to criticism isn't easy when you've invested lots of time and energy in a project, but good feedback provides a valuable opportunity to learn and to improve the quality of your work.

TABLE 2.2 Giving Constructive Feedback

How to Be Constructive	Explanation
Think through your suggested changes carefully.	Many business documents must illustrate complex relationships between ideas and other information, so isolated and superficial edits can do more harm than good.
Discuss improvements rather than flaws.	Instead of saying "this is confusing," for instance, explain how the writing can be improved to make it clearer.
Focus on controllable behavior.	The writer may not have control over every variable that affects the quality of the message, so focus on those aspects the writer can control.
Be specific.	Comments such as "I don't get this" or "Make this clearer" don't give the writer much direction.
Keep feedback impersonal.	Focus comments on the message, not on the person who created it.
Verify understanding.	If in doubt, ask for confirmation from the recipient to make sure that the person understood your feedback.
Time your feedback carefully.	Respond in a timely fashion so that the writer will have sufficient time to implement the changes you suggest.
Highlight any limitations your feedback may have.	If you didn't have time to give the document a thorough edit, or if you're not an expert in some aspect of the content, let the writer know so that he or she can handle your comments appropriately.

In contrast to constructive feedback, **destructive feedback** is little more than complaining or bullying. For example, "This proposal is a confusing mess, and you failed to convince me of anything" is destructive feedback. The goal is to be helpful: "Your proposal could be more effective with a clearer description of the manufacturing process and a well-organized explanation of why the positives outweigh the negatives." When giving feedback, avoid personal attacks and give the person clear guidelines for improvement.

In contrast to constructive feedback, *destructive feedback* is little more than complaining or bullying.

TECHNOLOGIES FOR COLLABORATIVE COMMUNICATION

A variety of tools and systems are available to help writers collaborate on everything from short documents to presentations to formal reports. The simplest tools are software features such as *commenting* (which lets colleagues write comments in a document without modifying the document text) and *change tracking* (which lets one or more writers propose changes to the text while keeping everyone's edits separate and reversible). Some systems also support live, online collaboration so you can work on documents with other people at the same time.

A wide variety of tools can help professionals work together, from editing features up to sophisticated collaboration platforms.

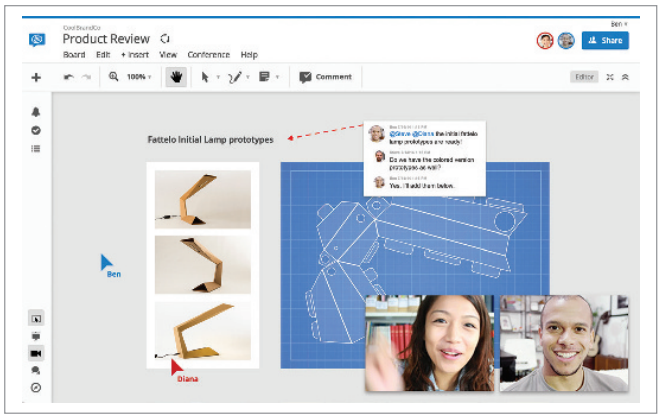
Collaboration Systems

Companies use a variety of systems to foster collaboration. Many of these rely on *cloud computing*, which means that the primary software and work files reside on the internet, making it easier for everyone on the team to gain access to the files.

Collaboration systems continue to evolve and add new capabilities, so the labels and the lines between various platforms are always a bit blurry, but here are some of the major types of collaboration platforms:

Collaboration platforms include
- Content management systems
- Wikis
- Shared online workspaces
- Social networks
- Workgroup messaging systems
- Intranets and extranets

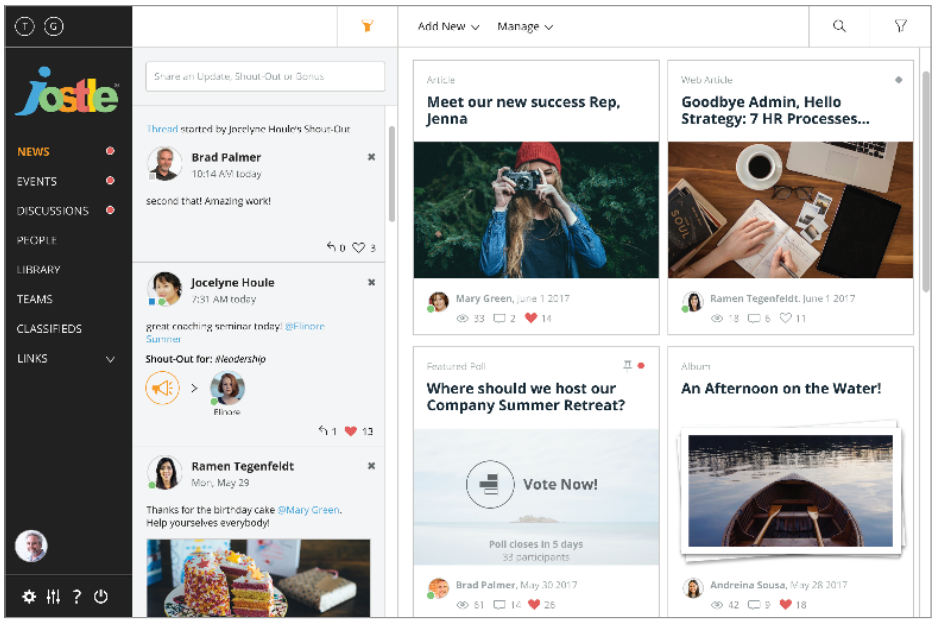
- **Content management systems** (**CMS**) help companies that produce a high volume of digital information for both internal and external distribution. These systems often include such features as *version control* (making sure two people can't unknowingly edit a document or page at the same time) and *work flow* features that define how content can be created, edited, and published.
- **Wikis** also organize digital content but in a much less structured and formal way than a CMS. A **wiki** is a website that allows anyone with access to add new material and edit existing material. Chapter 8 offers guidelines for effective wiki collaboration.
- **Shared online workspaces** are "virtual offices" that give everyone in a work group access to the same set of resources and information. Many offer real-time collaboration tools such as digital whiteboards where colleagues can brainstorm together (see Figure 2.2 on the next page).



Courtesy of Conceptboard

Figure 2.2 Shared Online Workspaces
Shared workspaces give employees remote access to all the files they need, from company reports to website content.

- **Social networks** are used extensively for business collaboration, and many companies have private, internal-only versions of social networks for their employees. Some companies use social networks to form *virtual communities* or *communities of practice* that link employees with similar professional interests throughout the company and sometimes with customers and suppliers as well. Chapter 8 has more on business uses of social networking.
- **Workgroup messaging systems** are evolving beyond basic messaging capability to include file sharing, meeting hosting, and other collaboration features.
- **Private networks** are essentially private versions of the internet with various communication and collaboration features. You may see some of these referred to as *intranets* (open to employees only) or *extranets* (open to employees and to selected outside parties by invitation only). Some intranets have now evolved into social networking systems that include a variety of communication and collaboration tools (see Figure 2.3).



©Jostle Corporation

Figure 2.3 Social Intranets
Social intranets such as Jostle help teams, departments, and entire companies communicate, celebrate, collaborate, and share resources.

INTELLIGENT COMMUNICATION TECHNOLOGY

Hi, I'm an Algorithm, Your New Teammate

If the thought of living in some sci-fi future where you work side by side with robot colleagues makes you uneasy, you might as well relax—you're already doing it. The internet and mobile phone apps are teeming with *bots*, pieces of software that perform a wide variety of tasks. They may not have mechanical arms and cute or creepy humanoid faces, but they are robots just the same.

The distinctions can be a little vague, but bots can be divided into two general categories: *taskbots* and *chatbots*. As their names suggest, one primarily handles chores and the other engages in conversation. Chatbots such as Apple's Siri and Amazon's Alexa use voice interaction, whereas many online chatbots use text input and output.

Taskbots are a key feature in robotic process automation, where they can take over tasks such as creating database reports, finding customer records, automating payroll, and processing orders. AI-enabled bots used in cognitive automation can become subject-matter experts and take over or assist with higher-level decision-making.

By one estimate, business professionals spend 10 to 20 percent of their work hours on routine tasks. With any luck, robotic teammates will handle the bulk of the mundane tasks in tomorrow's business environment and free up people to focus on strategic and creative thinking.

WHAT'S YOUR TAKE?

1. Would you rather work alongside a human teammate who occasionally makes mistakes that cost you time and energy or an AI-enabled taskbot that performs flawlessly? Explain your answer.
2. Would you be comfortable getting a medical diagnosis from a bot? Why or why not?

Sources: Suhasini Gadam, "AI, Automation, and the Future of Work," Automation Anywhere, 16 January 2019, www.automationanywhere.com; "Enabling Interaction with Bots," Slack, accessed 6 March 2019, www.slack.com; Clint Boulton, "How Messaging Bots Will Change Workplace Productivity," *CIO*, 1 February 2016, www.cio.com.

Collaboration via Mobile Devices

Mobile devices add another layer of options for collaborative writing and other communication projects. Today's mobile systems can do virtually everything that desk-based systems can do, from writing on virtual whiteboards to sharing photos, videos, and other multimedia files.[21] Mobility lets workers participate in online brainstorming sessions, seminars, and other formal or informal events from wherever they happen to be at the time.

An important aspect of mobile collaboration and mobile communication in general is **unified communication**, which integrates such capabilities as voice and video calling, voice and video conferencing, instant messaging, and real-time collaboration software into a single system.[22]

Unified communication integrates voice and video calling, conferencing, instant messaging, and other features in a single system.

AI-Enabled Collaboration

The latest innovation in collaboration tools is artificial intelligence, using AI-enabled bots and other tools to help people work more efficiently and effectively. For example, *taskbots* can assist teams with scheduling, data collection, document distribution, and other routine chores to give teams more time to focus on their work. Some bots can guide online discussions and project-update meetings. Systems such as Slack treat bots as team members; they can be assigned tasks and can assign tasks to their human teammates.[23] See "Intelligent Communication Technology: Hi, I'm an Algorithm, Your New Teammate."

Taskbots can help teams be more productive by taking over routine chores, such as scheduling.

Making Your Meetings More Productive

3 LEARNING OBJECTIVE
List the key steps needed to ensure productive meetings.

Much of your workplace communication will occur during in-person or online meetings, so your ability to contribute to the company—and to be recognized for your contributions—will depend to a large degree on your meeting skills. Well-run meetings can help companies solve problems, develop ideas, and identify opportunities. Meetings can also be a great way to promote team building through the experience of social interaction.[24] As useful as meetings can be, though, they can be a waste of time if they aren't planned and managed well.

PREPARING FOR MEETINGS

Check out the "Five-Minute Guide to Better Business Meetings" at the end of the chapter.

The first step in preparing for a meeting is to make sure the meeting is truly necessary. Meetings can consume hundreds or thousands of dollars of productive time while taking people away from other work, so don't hold a meeting if some other form of communication (such as a blog post) can serve the purpose as effectively.[25] If a meeting is indeed necessary, proceed with these four planning tasks.

Define the Meeting's Purpose

A good way to define the purpose of a meeting is to visualize the best possible outcome.

Meetings can focus on exchanging information, reaching decisions, or collaborating to solve problems or identify opportunities. Whatever your purpose, define the best possible result of the meeting (such as "we carefully evaluated all three product ideas and decided which one to invest in"). Use this hoped-for result to shape the direction and content of the meeting.[26] If you can't envision an ideal outcome from the meeting or express its purpose in a single sentence, keep brainstorming until you can narrow down to a specific purpose.

Select Participants for the Meeting

Keep meeting attendance as small as possible to ensure productive use of everyone's time.

The rule here is simple: Invite everyone who really needs to be involved, and don't invite anyone who doesn't. The more people you have, the longer it will take to reach consensus. Meetings with more than 10 or 12 people can become unmanageable if everyone is expected to participate in the discussion and decision-making. Of course, you can't always control who gets invited to meetings, but when you can, make deliberate choices.

Choose the Venue and the Time

If you can, optimize the seating to support the specific needs of each meeting.

Online meetings (see page 91) are often the best way and sometimes the only way to connect people in multiple locations or to reach large audiences. For in-person meetings, review the facility and the seating arrangements (see Figure 2.4). Pay attention to room temperature, lighting, ventilation, acoustics, and refreshments; these details can make or break a meeting. If you have control over the timing, morning meetings can be more productive because people are generally more alert and not yet engaged with the work of the day.

Set the Agenda

A good agenda identifies
- What needs to happen in the meeting
- Which issues are most important to discuss
- What information is required to discuss them

The success of any meeting depends on preparation. Distribute a carefully written *agenda* to participants, giving them enough time to prepare as needed (see Figure 2.5 on page 88). A productive agenda answers three questions: (1) What do we need to do in this meeting to accomplish our goals? (2) What issues will be of greatest importance to all participants? (3) What information must be available to discuss these issues?[27] Your company may have a standard agenda template for meetings; if not, you can get templates within Microsoft Word or other programs.

In addition to the detailed planning agenda, you may also want to prepare a simpler presentation agenda to use during the meeting (see Figure 2.6 on page 88). You can use this version to keep the meeting on track and remind everyone of how much time is allotted for each step.

LEADING AND CONTRIBUTING TO EFFICIENT MEETINGS

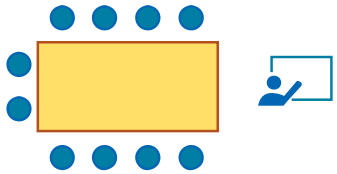
Everyone shares the responsibility for successful meetings.

Everyone in a meeting shares the responsibility for making the meeting productive. If you're the leader, however, you have an extra degree of responsibility and accountability. The following guidelines will help leaders and participants contribute to more effective meetings:

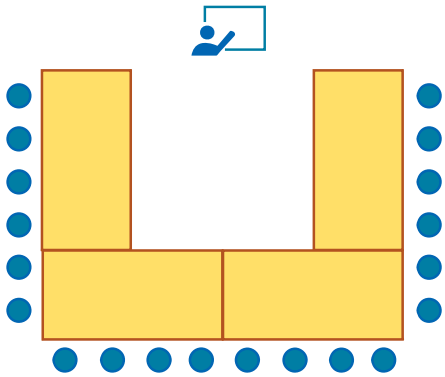
- **Keep the discussion on track.** Good leaders occasionally need to guide, mediate, probe, stimulate, summarize, and redirect discussions that have gotten off track. Don't leave it all in the leader's hands, however; everyone should help keep the meeting focused and moving forward.[28]

Make sure all styles of communicators have the opportunity to share their ideas.

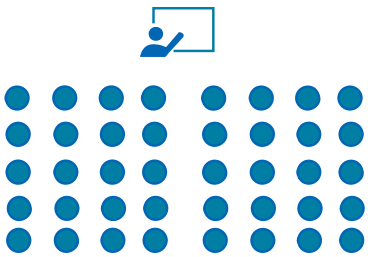
- **Follow agreed-on rules.** The larger the meeting, the more formal you need to be to maintain order. Formal meetings sometimes use **parliamentary procedure**, a



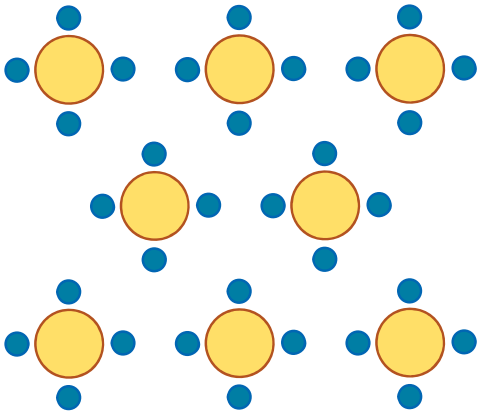
Conference room
Ideal for small meetings and working sessions; also works for small presentations by positioning presenter at one end of the table; promotes conversation among all attendees



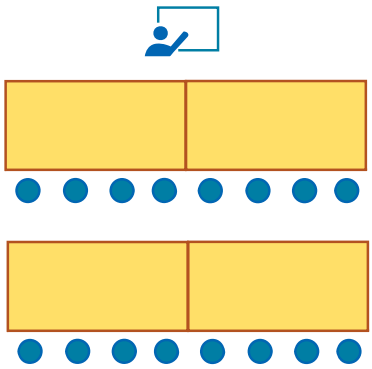
U-shape
Ideal for mid-sized meetings and working sessions; works nicely for presentations and gives the presenter the freedom to walk around the interior for closer interaction with attendees; also supports conversation among attendees



Theater/auditorium style
Best for large audiences but limits interaction between presenter and audience and among audience members; difficult for audiences to work with documents or devices unless chairs include desk surfaces



Breakout sessions
Useful for working meetings or seminars in which you ask the audience to split into groups and engage in role playing, brainstorming, or problem solving; prevents interaction between groups, however



Classroom style
Good alternative to theater/auditorium style when you want to give participants more work surface for devices and documents; less opportunity for interaction and conversation than U-shape

Figure 2.4 Meeting Room Configurations
If you have the option of configuring the meeting room, select the best seating arrangement for each meeting's purpose. Here are some of the more common configurations and their best uses for meetings and presentations.

time-tested method for planning and running effective meetings. The best-known guide to this procedure is *Robert's Rules of Order*.

- **Encourage and moderate participation.** Some people like to think out loud, using discussion to help clarify their own thoughts. Others prefer to finalize their thoughts before speaking. Effective meeting leaders need to accommodate both styles, in addition to making sure that people who may not feel comfortable speaking up or who have been interrupted by more assertive participants have the chance to be heard.[29]

Merger Issues Brainstorming Session

Location:	Building C, Saratoga room
Date:	August 8
Time:	9:00 to 12:00
Facilitator:	Irene Belden
Objectives	• Identify/confirm all major issues and problems in each functional area • Identify any cross-functional issues • Give functional managers information they need to formulate action plans
Prestudy:	Please download and read Merger Brainstorming Session Prestudy.docx

Agenda items

Time slot	Topic	Discussion leader
9:00-9:15	**Introductions:** Please be prepared to briefly describe your role on the transition team.	Irene Belden
9:15-10:00	**General transition costs:** Key items identified so far are severance packages, infrastructure investments, and service contracts.	Kip Selbach
10:00-10:15	**Break**	
10:15-11:00	**Information systems:** Key issues are migration to cloud computing and choice of internal communication platform.	Summer Bowman
11:00-11:45	**Marketing and sales:** Key issues are brand integration, sales force realignment, and quota and commission questions.	Ed Delahanty
11:45-12:00	**Wrap up:** Last call for questions and concerns; we want to make sure functional managers go away with every significant issue in hand so they can develop concrete action plans.	Irene Belden

Please send any questions to irene.belden@calypsonet.com

Figure 2.5 Effective Meeting Agenda: Full Version
A meeting agenda should provide all attendees with the information they need to plan for the meeting. Compare this full *planning agenda* with the shorter *presentation agenda* in Figure 2.6.

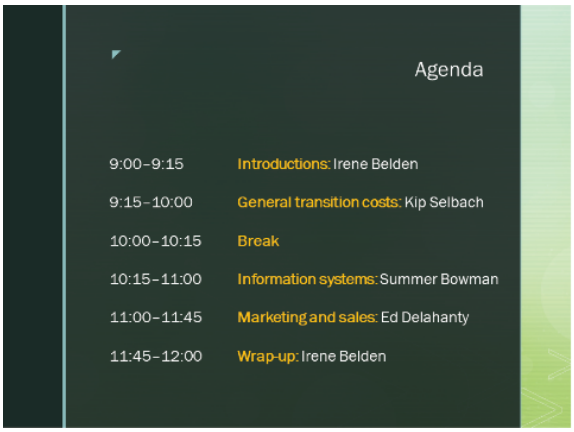


Figure 2.6 Effective Meeting Agenda: Condensed
This presentation slide shows a condensed version of the meeting agenda from Figure 2.5. The meeting facilitator can use a slide such as this to introduce each agenda item and keep the meeting on schedule.

- **Participate actively.** Make a point to contribute to the progress of the meeting and the smooth interaction of participants. Speak up if you have something useful to say, but don't talk or ask questions just to demonstrate how much you know about the subject at hand.
- **Don't interrupt.** Even if you're an expert in the subject matter or the discussion is getting heated, respect everyone's right to participate. Meetings can be dominated by the most aggressive participants, but the loudest people don't necessarily have the best ideas.
- **Use mobile devices respectfully.** Using mobile devices for taking notes during a meeting or presentation is becoming common, but make sure it is accepted practice in your company before you do so.
- **Close effectively.** At the conclusion of the meeting, verify that the objectives have been met or arrange for follow-up work, if needed. Summarize the general conclusion of the discussion and any actions to be taken. Make sure all participants understand and agree on the outcome.

Norms regarding mobile device usage vary widely; make sure you understand what your team or company expects.

PUTTING MEETING RESULTS TO PRODUCTIVE USE

In most cases, the value of a meeting doesn't end when the meeting ends. For example, problems or opportunities brought up during a meeting need to be addressed, any action items assigned during the meeting need to be acted on, and key decisions and announcements should be distributed to anyone who is affected but was unable to attend. Having a written, audio, or video record of a meeting also gives the participants a chance to verify their impressions and conclusions.

The conventional method of recording meetings is through written **minutes,** a summary of the important information presented and the decisions made (see Figure 2.7 on the next page). One person is usually assigned to keep notes as the meeting progresses and then to share them afterward.

Minutes are written summaries of important information presented and the decisions made in meetings.

The specific format of the minutes is less important than making sure you record all the key information, particularly regarding responsibilities that were assigned during the meeting. Typical elements include a list of those present and a list of those who were invited but didn't attend, followed by the times the meeting started and ended, all major decisions reached at the meeting, all assignments of tasks to meeting participants, and all subjects that were deferred to a later meeting. Minutes should objectively summarize important discussions, noting the names of those who contributed major points. Any handouts, slides, or supporting documents can be attached to the minutes when they are distributed.

Depending on the meeting technologies at your disposal, you may have software specifically designed to record, distribute, and store meeting minutes (see Figure 2.8 on page 91). Some systems automatically forward action items to each employee, record audio discussions for future playback, and make all the relevant documents and files available in one convenient place.[30]

To review the tasks that contribute to productive meetings, refer to "Checklist: Improving Meeting Productivity."

CHECKLIST ✓ Improving Meeting Productivity

A. Prepare carefully.
- Make sure the meeting is necessary.
- Decide on your purpose.
- Select participants carefully.
- Choose the venue and the time; adapt the seating if possible.
- Create and distribute a clear and detailed planning agenda.

B. Lead effectively and participate fully.
- Keep the meeting on track.
- Follow agreed-on rules.
- Encourage and moderate participation.
- Participate actively.
- Don't interrupt.
- Use mobile devices respectfully and in line with group norms.
- Close effectively.

C. Put the results to effective use.
- Distribute meeting minutes to participants and other interested parties.
- Make sure task assignments are clearly communicated.

Employee Onboarding Update

March 16
2:00 p.m. to 3:00 p.m.

Meeting called by: Alex Gardner **Type of meeting:** Status update

Facilitator: Jessica Knowdell **Note taker:** Frank Isbell

Attendees: Alex Gardner, Frank Isbell, Jessica Knowdell, Steve Ladew, Ally Lawson, Bill Swarback, Jessie Tannehill, Toni Von Fricken, Dale Williams

Minutes

Agenda item: New orientation presentation **Presenter:** Toni Von Fricken

Discussion:

Toni reports that the new slide presentation is complete and will be test-run with a group of volunteers from HR on March 30.

Steve offered to convert the slides to a video and post on the intranet.

Action items	Person responsible	Deadline
✓ Test-run new orientation presentation; fine-tune as needed	Toni VF	April 2
✓ Convert finished slides to video and post on employee intranet	Steve L	April 10

Agenda item: Update employee handbook and improve access **Presenter:** Jessica Knowdell

Discussion:

Team reached agreement that a wiki is the best platform for hosting the handbook.

We decided on a three-level access plan:

Level 1: Access open to all HR employees, but new posts and edits must be approved by division HR directors to ensure compliance (for all policy-related documents and regulatory forms)

Level 2: Access open to all HR employees, with immediate posting and editing allowed (for all non-policy documents, HR event updates, wellness bulletins, and similar items)

Level 3: Access open to all employees, with immediate posting and editing allowed (for all employee social clubs, charity events, and similar items)

Action items	Person responsible	Deadline
✓ Discuss wiki plan with intranet platform vendor	Jessica K	April 5
✓ Vendor to design access controls	Jessica K (vendor contact)	April 20
✓ Announce new wiki to employee base	Dale W, Jessica K	May 1

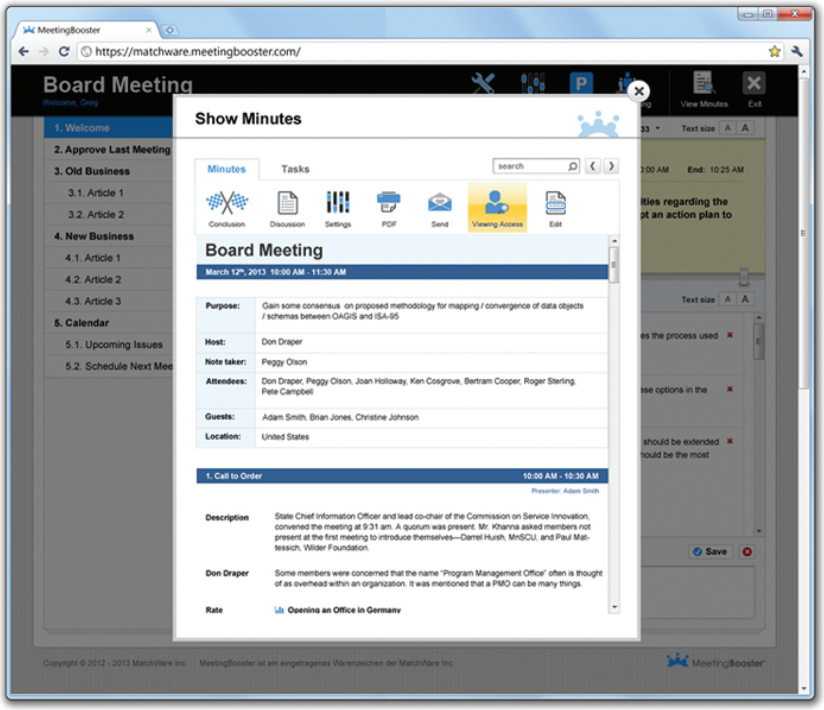
Agenda item: Brainstorm ideas for mentor matching program **Presenter:** Ally Lawson

Discussion:

Ally presented research on mentoring programs, including best practices and pitfalls.

Alex will bring up issue of volunteer vs. mandatory mentoring at May executive council.

Figure 2.7 Effective Meeting Minutes
Meeting minutes should record all the information that participants may need to refer to later. Depending on the circumstances, you might want to include information that anyone who wasn't able to attend can review to get a summary of key discussion and decision points.



©MeetingBooster

Figure 2.8 Capturing Key Decisions and Discoveries from a Meeting
Meeting tools such as the MeetingBooster system help teams and other groups capture decisions and discoveries from meetings and put this information to productive use.

CONDUCTING VIRTUAL MEETINGS

Virtual meetings are meetings in which people join in from two or more locations and connect via some form of communication technology. Such meetings are common in business today, so it's important to know how to run a virtual meeting and how to get the most out of one as a participant. Chances are you'll also participate in online seminars, often referred to as *webinars*.

Virtual meetings allow people to join in from two or more locations and connect via some form of communication technology.

Virtual Meeting Systems

The tools for virtual meetings range from conference calls and group messaging chats to real-time collaboration systems and *telepresence* systems with immersive video so realistic it can seem like people thousands of miles away are sitting across the table.[31] The most exotic systems can transmit *holograms*, beaming live, three-dimensional replicas of participants long distance.[32]

Teleconferencing is an easy and inexpensive choice that works well for many routine meetings. However, if the meeting will cover complex topics, explore issues with a strong emotional component, or require brainstorming or other interactive participation, some form of video link is highly desirable. Video supports a much wider range of nonverbal communication, and the ability to see one another helps new team members form closer bonds in less time (see Figure 2.9 on the next page). Fortunately, videoconferencing no longer requires expensive, dedicated systems. Several smartphone apps support small group video calls, and WebRTC (for *real-time communication*) capability lets people communicate via video through standard web browsers and mobile apps.[33]

MOBILE APP
Cisco WebEx Meetings gives you mobile access to one of the world's most popular online meeting platforms.

Tips for Successful Virtual Meetings

Virtual meetings require an extra level of planning and attention, in addition to the meeting planning steps covered earlier. Keeping people engaged can be more challenging, particularly in audio-only meetings. Follow these tips:



Zoom Video Communications

Figure 2.9 Virtual Meetings
Today's videoconferencing systems help virtual teams and geographically dispersed organizations communicate more effectively.

Conducting successful virtual meetings requires extra planning beforehand and more diligence during the meeting.

- Make sure the meeting has a well-defined task so that it steadily moves toward a goal and discourages people to fill the time with unrelated tasks.[34]
- Provide prestudy materials as needed, in addition to the agenda. Let participants know what will be expected of them.
- For large meetings, assign people to specific roles, such as a facilitator who guides the discussion, a technical specialist who can help people if they experience difficulties with their connections without interrupting the meeting, and someone to record the minutes.[35]
- Make sure everyone has up-to-date versions of whatever software tools you plan to use.
- If all the participants don't know each other, the facilitator should perform introductions or ask people in turn to introduce themselves.[36]
- If the system doesn't offer a way for people to virtually "raise their hands" to ask a question, the facilitator should explain how to pose questions.
- Log in on time. Meeting systems often announce or signal as each person checks in, and it's highly disruptive when latecomers log in after the meeting has started.

Avoid the temptation to multitask during a virtual meeting; stay present for your own benefit and the benefit of others.

- Be present, mentally and emotionally. Staying present shows respect for others, and it could save you from embarrassment if you get called on unexpectedly.
- Mute your audio input if you need to cough or otherwise make noise. Most systems have a microphone icon or mute button you can press.
- If you type to take notes, make sure noise from your keyboard won't distract others. If necessary, mute your audio while typing.

During virtual meetings, check in with everyone frequently to see if there are any points of confusion or disagreement.

- As you work through each agenda item, summarize what has been discussed and ask if anyone has questions or comments.[37]
- As the facilitator, periodically check in with each person, if feasible. For instance, if someone hasn't spoken in a while, you might address a person by name and ask, "Does that work for you?" or "Do you have anything to add?"

4 LEARNING OBJECTIVE
Explain why listening is such a complex communication process, and describe three steps to becoming a better listener.

Improving Your Listening Skills

Much of this course focuses on improving your skills as a sender of messages, but successful communication requires the mindful participation of both the sender and the receiver. When you are engaged in a conversation or listening to a live or recorded speaker,

the success of the communication effort hinges on your performance as a listener.[38] As OpenText's Mark Barrenechea (see page 75) would emphasize, listening is essential for acquiring information needed to create companies, to perform on the job, and to build a foundation for trust and successful relationships.[39]

You've been listening all your life, so it's natural to assume it's something you do well without even thinking about it. However, listening is a more complex process than you might imagine, and you surely know from your own life experiences how often listening can be unsuccessful.

Effective listening is more difficult than it might seem and requires active involvement to be successful.

This section explains why effective listening is more difficult than it seems and then outlines three positive steps you can take to become a more effective listener. (Note that even if your physical ability to hear is impaired, most of the issues and techniques discussed in this section can help.)

UNDERSTANDING WHY LISTENING IS SUCH A COMPLEX PROCESS

Listening is vulnerable to all the potential barriers and breakdowns that you considered in Chapter 1's discussion of the communication process, plus there are several difficulties that are unique to listening. In addition, various listener behaviors can get in the way of successful communication (see Table 2.3).

The Unique Challenges of Listening

Listening involves three unique challenges. First, conversations and presentations happen in real time, meaning you must be engaged while the speaker is talking and stay engaged the entire time. If you want to verify something or attend to an interruption while you're reading, you can simply pause and pick it up again later. However, doing so is awkward at best and sometimes impossible when you're in the middle of a live conversation or listening to a presentation. (Of course, if you're listening to a podcast or other recorded speech, you can pause and come back later.)

Because conversations and presentations happen in real time, you must stay engaged the entire time to avoid getting confused or lost.

Second, speech is invisible, in that you don't have written words to refer to if you get lost or confused. If your mind drifts for a moment while reading, you can scan back up the page to figure out what is going on. You don't have that luxury with conversation. If you get lost, you must ask the other party to stop the conversation and repeat or re-explain. While this conversational interactivity can be one of the key advantages of oral communication, it isn't always easy or possible. For instance, if the speaker is a top

Unlike written documents, speech doesn't give you a visual record to review if you get lost or confused.

TABLE 2.3 Factors That Complicate the Listening Process

Unique Challenges of Listening	Individual Choices and Behaviors
Real-time experience Conversation is consumed as it is created; you can't scroll back in time like you can with written communication.	**Poor self-management** Listeners need to actively manage their own emotions during a conversation; otherwise, these distractions will get in the way.
Invisibility You can't see spoken language, so you have no visual record to refer to if you get lost or confused.	**Idle brain power** The mind can process information several times faster than people can talk, and if listeners don't harness that extra processing power, their minds are likely to wander.
Sound-to-language conversion Incoming sounds must be converted to language before your mind can begin to process what is being said. Mumbling, strong accents, and ambient noise can all complicate this process.	**Ineffective listening style** Different conversations call for different styles of listening, and using an inappropriate style can hamper a conversational exchange.
	Barriers Listeners need to take steps to minimize barriers in their listening environment in order to reduce interruptions and distractions.
	Flawed recall If listeners don't record or actively memorize essential information during a conversation, chances are they will forget or confuse important details.

executive in your company or a trainer in a seminar, it can be intimidating to admit you are confused or weren't paying attention. Too often, it's tempting to stay quiet and hope you can guess what the speaker said or meant.

The need to convert incoming sounds to understandable language is a unique challenge of listening.

Third, before listeners can begin to decode incoming messages, they need to convert incoming sounds into recognizable words and sentences. Doing so adds a layer of complexity that doesn't exist in other media, and a variety of barriers can get in the way, including ambient noise, a speaker who is mumbling or who has a strong accent, and physical difficulties in hearing.

Choices and Behaviors That Affect Listening Quality

In addition to the generic challenges of listening, a variety of listener choices and behaviors can also degrade the quality of a communication exchange.

Listeners need to manage their emotions to avoid creating mental barriers and distractions.

- **Poor self-management.** Communication suffers if listeners fail to monitor and manage their emotions during a conversation. During the hectic workday or when emotions are running high, listening calmly and mindfully can be a challenge. However, these are the times when it is most important to exhibit emotional intelligence, including the ability to recognize when your emotions might be getting in the way.[40]
- **Idle brain power.** Your brain can process language three or four times faster than people typically speak, which means your brain has a lot of extra processing capacity while you're listening.[41] If you don't take active steps to keep focused, your mind will inevitably wander.
- **Ineffective listening style.** Even when listeners are actively engaged in conversations, the exchange can still suffer if they don't use the best *style* of listening for the situation at hand. See "Adapt Your Listening Style to the Situation" on page 95.
- **Barriers to physical reception.** Before you can listen to someone, you obviously need to be able to hear the other party speak. Missing even a single word can lead to confusion and misunderstanding. Poor hearing can originate on the speaker's side (such as when someone mumbles), on the receiver's side (such as when someone is listening to music during a conversation), or in the surrounding environment (such as when other people in an open-plan office are talking).

Memorization is an integral part of listening and can be a challenge because you need to store information you've just heard while new information continues to reach your ears.

- **Flawed recall.** Remembering information during a conversation is challenging because you need to store information you have just received while continuing to process new incoming information. This problem gets even more pronounced when the speaker is rambling or disorganized or fails to periodically summarize what he or she has said.

When you consider the complexity of the listening experience, it's not surprising that listening well is a universal challenge. Fortunately, with awareness and effort, everyone can take steps to overcome these hurdles.

BECOMING A BETTER LISTENER

Now that you have a sense of how listening can go off track, here are three vital steps to becoming a better listener: minimizing the barriers to effective listening, adapting your listening style to the situation, and engaging in active listening.

Minimize the Barriers to Effective Listening

You might not be able to control all the barriers that get in the way of effective listening, but the more you can reduce them, the more satisfying the experience will be for everyone involved. *External barriers* are anything in the environment or communication channel that make it difficult to hear the other party or focus on what is being said. If you can't fix a problem, take steps to minimize its effects, such as confirming key information by summarizing what you've heard during the call or later in

External barriers to listening are any factors that impede physical hearing or concentration.

writing. If you're having trouble hearing, let the other party know so you can both work to resolve the situation. Don't try to guess at what someone might have said and hope for the best.

Internal barriers are listener behaviors, thoughts, and emotions that hinder one's ability to understand, interpret, or accept what someone else is saying. They may not be as obvious as external barriers, but they can be much more disruptive. If you're not paying attention or are dividing your attention by multitasking, you will miss verbal information and nonverbal signals. Moreover, not paying attention is disrespectful and sends a message to the other person that what he or she has to say isn't important to you.[42]

Internal barriers to listening are listener behaviors, thoughts, and emotions that hinder understanding.

Selective attention and perceptual biases can lead listeners to mold messages to fit their own beliefs and conceptual frameworks. Listeners sometimes make up their minds before hearing the speaker's full message, or they engage in *defensive listening*—protecting their egos by tuning out anything that doesn't confirm their beliefs or their view of themselves. Feeling angry or annoyed during a conversation limits your effectiveness because you'll be more likely to judge or reject what you hear. "Listen Actively," starting on page 96, offers helpful advice for getting yourself in the right frame of mind.

Defensive listening involves protecting your ego by tuning out anything that doesn't confirm your beliefs or view of yourself.

Adapt Your Listening Style to the Situation

Effective listeners adapt their listening styles to different situations, including switching approaches over the course a conversation or presentation. You can use three distinct styles: *content* listening, *critical* listening, and *empathic* listening (see Table 2.4). Note that all three of these are forms of *active listening* (see the next section).

The primary goal of **content listening** is to understand and retain the information in the speaker's message. It doesn't matter whether you agree or disagree, approve or disapprove—only that you understand. Filter out anything other than the information itself, including the speaker's appearance, vocabulary, level of experience, or position in the company. If appropriate, ask questions to clarify any points you don't understand or to get more details. However, don't challenge or correct the speaker. Remember that your goal with content listening is to get the information that another person has to share. If the exchange starts to feel confrontational, he or she might "shut down" and hesitate to disclose valuable information.

Content listening is listening primarily to understand and retain the information in the speaker's message without evaluating it.

Critical listening goes beyond information gathering to evaluate the meaning of the speaker's message on several levels: the logic of the argument, the strength of the evidence, the validity of the conclusions, the implications of the message, the speaker's intentions and motives, and the omission of any important or relevant points. If you're skeptical, ask questions to explore the speaker's point of view and credibility. Be on the lookout for bias that might influence how the information is presented, separate opinions from facts, and watch for logical fallacies that could undermine the speaker's arguments or conclusions.[43] (Note that "critical listening" does not mean you are listening with the intent to criticize but rather to understand the full meaning and implications of the speaker's message.)

Critical listening adds the element of evaluation to content listening; it's not listening to criticize but rather to critically evaluate the message and the speaker's intentions.

TABLE 2.4 Three Styles of Listening

Listening Style	Goal
Content listening	Understand and retain the information the other party is sharing
Critical listening	Understand and evaluate the information in terms of logical arguments, strength of evidence, validity of conclusions, implications, and any omissions; understanding the speaker's motives may be relevant as well
Empathic listening	Understand the speaker's feeling, needs, and wants, regardless of whether you agree with his or her perspective

The goal of *empathic listening* is to understand the speaker's feelings, needs, and wants regardless of the information being shared.

The goal of **empathic listening** is to understand the speaker's feelings, needs, and wants so that you can appreciate his or her point of view, regardless of whether you share that perspective. Importantly, this style of listening gives the other person the freedom to share without fear of being judged or evaluated.[44] In this sense, empathic listening is a complementary skill to critical listening because you need to silence your critical faculties and focus your attention on the other person. In fact, the information exchanged in an empathic conversion is sometimes less important than simply giving someone the opportunity to be heard. Be aware that empathic listening can be a difficult habit to get into, particularly for people who are used to solving problems and taking charge of situations.[45]

Listen Actively

Active listening is making a conscious effort to engage with other people and to turn off your internal filters and biases to truly hear and understand what they are saying. (Content, critical, and empathic listening are all forms of active listening.)

To listen actively, start by putting yourself in an open and positive frame of mind.

By now, you probably recognize the most important point to understand about listening, which is that to be effective, it must be an *active* process. Listening well requires energy, effort, and attention. **Active listening** is making a conscious effort to engage with other people and to turn off your internal filters and biases in order to truly hear and understand what they are saying. This section describes five ways to help you listen more actively (see Table 2.5).

Put Yourself in an Open and Positive State of Mind Effective listening begins with putting yourself in the right frame of mind, which requires a conscious commitment to the other person and to the time you will be spending. Even if you aren't interested in the topic or aren't in the mood, you can will yourself to listen by viewing it as an opportunity to learn or to help. The more willing you are to listen, the better you'll be able to concentrate and the higher the chance that you'll accurately interpret what the other person is saying.[46]

Prepare yourself to have your beliefs challenged and to learn new information.[47] Accept that you might not have all the answers, even if you are an expert or the person in charge. This will help open your mind to what other people are saying.[48] To improve over time, commit to examining your own listening behaviors and, if necessary, changing how you listen to others.[49]

Keep Yourself Engaged As the discussion moves along, commit to staying engaged, which requires consciously managing your behaviors, thoughts, and emotions. Remember that your brain has excess processing capacity while you're listening, and it will wander off and find new things to think about if you let it. *Compartmentalizing* any thoughts and emotions unrelated to the topic at hand can also help you stay focused and engaged. If you are worried or excited about something unrelated to the conversation, visualize putting that emotion in a box inside your mind with the understanding that you will attend to it later.

Respect Silence Don't automatically speak at the first moment of silence. Sometimes silence is an important part of the conversation. The other person might be collecting his or her thoughts or looking for a clearer way to express something.[50] Also, if someone pauses in the middle of a sentence, don't rush in to complete it—particularly if your real motivation is to demonstrate superior knowledge or intelligence.[51]

TABLE 2.5 Five Elements of Active Listening

Element	Why It's Important
Open and positive state of mind	This mindset makes you receptive to new information and positive about the experience of listening to this person.
Active engagement	If you don't commit to being in and staying in the conversation, your mind will wander and the other person will sense that you aren't fully engaged.
Respect for silence	A moment of silence might be the speaker collecting or reconsidering his or her thoughts; if you step in too soon, you could interrupt the flow.
Nonverbal awareness	Intentional and unintentional nonverbal signals can explain and amplify the speaker's message.
Thoughtful note-taking	If the information is important, don't rely on your memory; it's too easy to forget key details.

Pay Attention to Nonverbal Signals One of the advantages of oral communication over written formats is the ability to see what isn't being said in the form of *nonverbal signals*. These include hand gestures, facial expressions, posture, eye contact, and so on. As "Improving Your Nonverbal Communication Skills" on page 98 explains, the information in the signals can strengthen, weaken, or even replace spoken language.

Take Thoughtful Notes If the information you are likely to receive is important, write it down. Don't rely on your memory. Chances are you will forget or confuse important details. Of course, the decision whether to take notes depends on the situation. If someone is sharing personal or confidential information or is asking for your advice, it might not be appropriate or necessary to take notes. If you are using a laptop or mobile device to take notes, make sure you can do so quickly enough to keep up with the conversation and in a way that doesn't disturb others.

Don't rely on your memory if you are hearing important information that you will need to act on later; record it or write it down.

In addition to recording information for later use, taking notes can help you engage with the speaker during a conversation or presentation. For instance, if you have questions or concerns, you can list them in your notes and refer to them when it's convenient to ask or during a scheduled question-and-answer period. Notes also help you stay engaged, and they can help you evaluate information when you are using critical listening.[52]

If you have no choice but to memorize information you are hearing, take active steps to transfer it from short-term memory to long-term memory.

If you are unable to take notes and have no choice but to memorize, you can hold information in short-term memory by repeating it silently or creating lists in your head. To store information in long-term memory, four techniques can help: (1) associate new information with something closely related (such as the restaurant in which you met a new client), (2) categorize the new information into logical groups (such as alphabetizing a list of names), (3) visualize words and ideas as pictures, and (4) create mnemonics such as acronyms or rhymes.

Table 2.6 summarizes the habits of effective and ineffective listeners. For a quick reminder of the steps you can take to become a better listener, see "Checklist: Improving Your Listening Skills."

TABLE 2.6 Behavioral Differences Between Effective and Ineffective Listeners

Effective Listeners	Ineffective Listeners
Listen actively	Listen passively
Put themselves in an open, positive frame of mind	Switch to listening without consideration, continuing in whatever emotional state they were in before
Stay focused on the speaker and the conversation	Allow their minds to wander, are easily distracted, or work on unrelated tasks
Take careful notes, when applicable	Take no notes or ineffective notes
Make frequent eye contact with the speaker (depends on culture to some extent)	Make little or no eye contact—or inappropriate eye contact
Keep their emotions under control and don't let their own anxieties poison the conversation	Allow their emotions to negatively influence the conversation
Mentally paraphrase key points to maintain attention level and ensure comprehension	Fail to paraphrase
Adjust listening style to the situation	Listen with the same style, regardless of the situation
Give the speaker nonverbal feedback (such as nodding to show agreement or raising eyebrows to show surprise or skepticism)	Fail to give the speaker nonverbal feedback
Save questions or points of disagreement until an appropriate time	Interrupt whenever they disagree or don't understand
Engage the other person with questions or encouragement; validate the other person's feelings	Fail to engage; offer no encouragement or expression of understanding
Overlook stylistic differences and focus on the speaker's message	Are distracted by or unduly influenced by stylistic differences; are judgmental
Make distinctions between main points and supporting details	Are unable to distinguish main points from details
Look for opportunities to learn	Assume they already know everything that's important to know

Sources: Judi Brownell, *Listening: Attitudes, Principles, and Skills,* 6th ed. (New York: Routledge, 2018), 6, 10–11, 19–20, 88–89; Jack Zenger and Joseph Folkman, "What Great Listeners Actually Do," *Harvard Business Review*, 14 July 2016, www.hbr.org; Amy Jen Su and Muriel Maignan Wilkins, "What Gets in the Way of Listening," *Harvard Business Review*, 14 April 2016, www.hbr.org; Madelyn Burley-Allen, *Listening: The Forgotten Skill,* 2nd ed. (New York: Wiley, 1995), 70–71, 119–120; Larry Barker and Kittie Watson, *Listen Up* (New York: St. Martin's, 2000), 8, 9, 64.

CHECKLIST ✓ Improving Your Listening Skills

- Recognize the unique challenges of listening and take steps to overcome them.
- Lower external barriers to physical reception whenever you can, such as minimizing ambient noise.
- Lower internal barriers to reception and understanding by monitoring and managing your own emotions.
- Try not to slip into defensive listening; be open to what you are hearing, even if you don't agree.
- Adapt your listening style to each situation.
- Commit to listening actively—put yourself in an open and positive frame of mind, keep yourself engaged, respect silence, be aware of nonverbal signals, and take notes if appropriate.
- Don't rely on your memory; write down or record important information.

Improving Your Nonverbal Communication Skills

5 LEARNING OBJECTIVE
Explain the importance of nonverbal communication, and identify six major categories of nonverbal expression.

Nonverbal communication is the process of sending and receiving information, both intentionally and unintentionally, without using language.

Nonverbal signals can convey a significant amount of information, but disregard any claims you might have heard about them conveying a specific percentage of message content.

Nonverbal communication is complex: Not all signals are controllable, and signals don't always mean what people think they mean.

Nonverbal signals include facial expressions; vocal characteristics; gestures, posture, and gait; personal appearance; touch; and use of time and space.

Nonverbal communication is the process of sending and receiving information, both intentionally and unintentionally, without using language. Nonverbal signals play a vital role in communication because they can strengthen or repeat a verbal message (when the nonverbal signals match the words), weaken or contradict a verbal message (when nonverbal signals don't match the words), or replace words entirely.[53] Nonverbal signals aren't limited to your facial expressions, gestures, and other personal behaviors.

Nonverbal signals are a factor in virtually every instance of communication, and they can convey a significant portion of the information and emotions shared in interpersonal communication.[54] In fact, you may have heard the claim that nonverbal signals convey *most* of the message in face-to-face communication. You might even see specific percentages, such as that words carry only 7 percent of meaning and nonverbal elements carry 93 percent (with tone of voice making up 38 percent of that and body language the other 55 percent). However, the experiments that produced these figures more than 50 years ago attempted only to assess the feelings of the speaker and have not been confirmed by other research.[55] These percentages do not apply as a rule about nonverbal communication, so ignore any claim about words carrying only 7 percent of your meaning.

RECOGNIZING NONVERBAL COMMUNICATION

Nonverbal communication is an intriguing part of business communication because it is both complex and somewhat difficult to pin down. On the sending side, some nonverbal signals are controllable (such as choosing what to wear), some are habits you may not even think about (tapping your fingers when you're impatient, for instance), some are trainable (using specific hand gestures during a presentation), and some are involuntary (such as blushing).[56]

On the receiving side, nonverbal signals are not always reliable (a person who avoids eye contact isn't necessarily trying to hide something, for example), and people vary widely in their ability to interpret signals correctly.[57]

In a face-to-face conversation, everything from your body language to your clothing to your eye movements can influence the messages and meanings the other party takes away from the exchange. During a phone call, the pitch, rate, and other qualities of your voice can send nonverbal signals. Even with written messages (both printed and digital), design and formatting choices send nonverbal signals, although the focus here is on interpersonal communication. Six types of signals are particularly important (see Figure 2.10):

- **Facial expressions.** Your face is the primary vehicle for expressing your emotions because it can reveal both the type and the intensity of your feelings.[58] Facial expressions can also affect other people's emotions—a smile or frown, for instance, can trigger a similar response in anyone you are talking to.[59] Your eyes are especially effective for indicating attention and interest, influencing others, regulating interaction, and establishing dominance.[60]
- **Vocal characteristics.** Aspects of voice carry both intentional and unintentional messages. A speaker can intentionally control pitch, pace, and stress to convey a specific

Your entire physical being is a nonverbal transmitter:

- Face, particularly your mouth and eyes
- Voice and vocal characteristics
- Gesture and posture
- Personal appearance
- Touch
- Use of time and space



Figure 2.10 The Importance of Nonverbal Signals
You send nonverbal signals continuously via just about every aspect of your physical being.

message. For instance, compare "*What* are you doing?" and "What are *you* doing?" Unintentional vocal characteristics can convey happiness, surprise, fear, and other emotions (for example, fear often increases the pitch and pace of your speaking voice).

Subtleties in intonation or emphasis can completely alter the meaning of a spoken message.

- **Gesture and posture.** The way you position and move your body expresses both specific and general messages, some voluntary and some involuntary. Many gestures—a wave of the hand, for example—have specific and intentional meanings. Other types of body movement can express meanings that may be unintended. Slouching, leaning forward, fidgeting, and walking briskly are all unconscious signals that can reveal whether you feel confident or nervous, friendly or hostile, assertive or passive, powerful or powerless.
- **Personal appearance.** People respond to others on the basis of their physical appearance, sometimes fairly and other times unfairly. Although an individual's body type and facial features define appearance to a large degree, you can control grooming, clothing, accessories, piercings, tattoos, and hairstyle. To make a good impression, adopt the style of the people you want to impress. Employers differ widely in their expectations of personal appearance, so make sure you are aware of your company's dress code, if it has one.
- **Touch.** Touch is an important way to convey warmth, comfort, and reassurance—as well as control. Touch is so powerful, in fact, that it is governed by cultural customs that establish who can touch whom and how in various circumstances. Even within each culture's norms, however, individual attitudes toward touch vary widely. A manager might be comfortable using hugs to express support or congratulations, but his or her subordinates could interpret those hugs as a show of dominance or sexual interest.[61] In other words, touch is a complex subject. Other than handshakes, the best general advice is to avoid touching anyone under any circumstances in the workplace. If someone else takes the initiative, you can choose to reciprocate if you want, but *only* if you are comfortable doing so.

Touch is a powerful element of communication, but it can be misused and misunderstood; as a general rule for the workplace, avoid any touching other than handshakes.

- **Time and space.** Like touch, time and space can be used to assert authority, imply intimacy, and send other nonverbal messages. For instance, some people try to demonstrate their own importance or disregard for others by making other people wait; others show respect by being on time. Similarly, taking care not to invade private space, such as standing too close when talking, is a way to show respect for others. Keep in mind that expectations regarding time and space vary by culture.

USING NONVERBAL COMMUNICATION EFFECTIVELY

Paying attention to nonverbal cues will make you a better speaker and a better listener. When you're talking, be conscious of the nonverbal cues you are sending, and use them to reinforce your spoken message. For example, if you want to persuade someone to collaborate with you on a project, don't lean back in your chair with your arms crossed while making your pitch. An open and forward posture will reinforce your message of cooperation.

Make sure the nonverbal signals you send don't undermine your efforts to succeed on the job.

Also consider the nonverbal signals you send when you're not talking—the clothes you wear, the way you sit, the way you walk. Whether or not you think it is fair to be judged on superficial matters, the truth is that you are judged this way. Don't let careless choices or disrespectful habits undermine all the great work you're doing on the job. In addition, be mindful of how your dress and grooming choices affect your own attitude. If you believe that you've made the effort to look your best, you will feel more confident, and that confidence will manifest itself in a variety of positive nonverbal signals.[62]

When you listen, pay attention to the speaker's nonverbal cues. Do they amplify, obscure, or contradict the spoken words? Is the speaker intentionally using nonverbal signals to send you a message that he or she can't put into words? A thin, forced smile in response to "How did your meeting with the boss go?" probably says that it didn't go well but that the person isn't ready to talk about it. As you gain experience in the workplace, reflect on the conversations you have with managers, colleagues, and customers. Compare the verbal messages you receive with the nonverbal signals that accompany them. Over time, you'll develop a better sense of how the people around you use nonverbal signals.

Don't assume you can "read someone like a book," particularly if you don't know the person's normal behavioral patterns.

Be observant, but don't assume you can "read someone like a book," particularly if you don't know the person's normal behavioral patterns.[63] For example, contrary to popular belief, avoiding eye contact and covering one's face while talking are not reliable clues that someone is lying. Even when telling the truth, most people don't make uninterrupted eye contact with listeners, and various gestures such as touching one's face might be normal behavior for some people.[64] Moreover, these and other behaviors may be influenced by culture (in some cultures, sustained eye contact can be interpreted as a sign of disrespect) or might just be ways of coping with stressful situations.[65]

If something doesn't feel right, ask the speaker an honest and respectful question. Doing so may clear everything up, or it may uncover issues you need to explore further. See "Checklist: Improving Your Nonverbal Communication Skills" for a summary of key ideas regarding nonverbal skills.

CHECKLIST ✓ Improving Your Nonverbal Communication Skills

- Understand the roles that nonverbal signals play in communication—complementing verbal language by strengthening, weakening, or replacing words.
- Note that facial expressions (especially eye contact) can reveal the type and intensity of a speaker's feelings.
- Watch for cues from gestures and posture.
- Listen for vocal characteristics that can signal the emotions underlying the speaker's words.
- Recognize that listeners are influenced by physical appearance.
- As a general workplace rule, avoid any physical contact beyond handshakes; touch can convey positive attributes but can also be interpreted as a show of dominance or sexual interest.
- Pay attention to the use of time and space.

Developing Your Business Etiquette

6 LEARNING OBJECTIVE
Explain the importance of business etiquette, and identify five key areas in which good etiquette is essential.

Etiquette, the expected norms of behavior in any particular situation, is essential to every aspect of interpersonal communication and team collaboration.

You may have noticed a common thread running through this chapter on the topics of teamwork, collaboration, productive meetings, and effective listening: All these activities depend on mutual respect and consideration among all participants. Nobody wants to work with someone who is rude to colleagues or an embarrassment to the company. Moreover, shabby treatment of others in the workplace can be a huge drain on morale and productivity.[66]

A vital element of audience-centered communication is **etiquette**, the expected norms of polite behavior in any situation. Poor etiquette can drive away customers, investors, and other critical audiences—and it can limit your career potential. Unfortunately, rude behavior appears to be on the rise, so the issue is more important than ever.[67]



Figure 2.11 The Five Zones of Professional Etiquette
Professionals pay attention to their effect on other people in five areas: in the workplace, in social settings in which they are representing their firms, while online, while using the telephone, and while using mobile devices.

This section addresses some key etiquette points to remember in a variety of work and work-related settings (see Figure 2.11). Long lists of etiquette rules can be difficult to remember, but you can get by in almost every situation by remembering to be aware of your effect on others, treating everyone with respect, and keeping in mind that the impressions you leave behind can have a lasting effect on you and your company.

BUSINESS ETIQUETTE IN THE WORKPLACE

Workplace etiquette includes a variety of behaviors, habits, and aspects of nonverbal communication. Follow these tips to help ensure a pleasant and productive workplace:[68]

- Respect other people's time, such as showing up for work and meetings on time.
- Don't interrupt people in conversations or in meetings.
- Watch your language. You might be comfortable with profanity in casual conversation, but it is out of place in a professional environment.
- Pay close attention to cleanliness, and avoid using products with powerful scents. Many people are bothered by these products, and some are allergic to them.
- Avoid eating at your desk if possible, particularly in open-plan offices. Some foods have strong smells, and no one wants to listen to you eat.
- Keep the noise level down. This is a huge concern in open-plan workspaces, where people are separated only by short cubicle walls and sometimes not even that. Keep your voice down, avoid having meetings in your cubicle, and don't play music at a level that disrupts others. (Remember that you can bother others even if you're wearing earbuds or headphones.)
- Respect other people's personal space. Knock before entering offices, and don't enter someone's cubicle without being invited.
- Don't gossip. Not only is gossip a waste of time, it's often disrespectful to others.
- Don't come to work when you're sick.
- In general, avoid discussing religion, politics, or other potentially emotional issues, unless your company encourages such discussions.

Noise can be a big problem in today's open-plan offices, so take care to avoid disrupting others.

Avoid coming to work when you're sick.

Although it isn't always thought of as an element of etiquette, your personal appearance in the workplace sends a strong signal to managers, colleagues, and customers (see Figure 2.12 on the next page). This isn't a question of mindlessly conforming or surrendering your individuality; it's a question of showing respect for an organizational culture that is bigger than you.

Pay attention to the style of dress where you work, and adjust your style to match. Expectations for specific jobs, companies, and industries vary widely. Firms in the financial sector tend to be more formal than high-tech, creative, and industrial companies,

Pay attention to the style of dress where you work and adjust your style to match.



Paul Bradbury/OJO Images Ltd/Alamy Stock Photo

Figure 2.12 Showing Respect for Organizational Culture
The choices you make regarding personal appearance and behavior can send a strong signal to managers, colleagues, and customers regarding your level of respect for workplace norms.

for instance, and sales and executive positions usually involve more formal expectations than positions in engineering or manufacturing.

Work attire falls into four degrees of formality:
- Business formal
- Business professional
- Business casual
- Casual

You can view business style as four levels:[69]

- **Business formal.** This means tailored suits in conservative colors, with shoes, accessories, and grooming to match. This style is usually restricted only to the most formal occasions or among top-level executives and high-profile professionals.
- **Business professional.** This style is still based around suits or coordinated sets of jackets with skirts or trousers, but the overall vibe is slightly freer—and less expensive.
- **Business casual.** This is the style adopted in more relaxed offices in a variety of industries and professions. In general, it means slacks or skirts, with nice-looking button-up shirts, blouses, and sweaters.
- **Casual.** This category is perhaps the most difficult to pin down. In one company it might mean nice jeans and a button-up shirt, but in another it might be shorts, sandals, and tank tops.

In general, the trend in U.S. offices is toward casual, but don't overstep the boundaries in place at your specific office. Observe others, and don't be afraid to ask for advice. Many clothing stores, department stores, and online retailers such as Stitchfix (**www.stitchfix.com**) offer personal shopping guidance or style guides to help you select garments. If you're not sure, dress modestly and simply—earn a reputation for what you do, not for what you wear.

BUSINESS ETIQUETTE IN SOCIAL SETTINGS

Etiquette is particularly important when you represent your company in public.

From business lunches to industry conferences, you may be asked to represent your company in public. Make sure your appearance and actions are appropriate to the situation. Get to know the customs of other cultures when it comes to meeting new people. For example, in North America, a firm handshake is expected when two people meet, whereas a respectful bow of the head is more appropriate in Japan. If you are physically able, always stand when shaking someone's hand.

When introducing yourself, state your first and last name and include a brief description of your role in the company.

When introducing yourself, state your first and last name and include a brief description of your role in the company. When introducing two other people, give their first and last names clearly and then try to offer some information (perhaps a shared professional interest) to help the two people ease into a conversation.[70]

Generally speaking, introduce younger people to older people and lower-ranking employees or managers to higher-ranking managers.[71]

Business is often conducted over meals, and knowing the basics of dining etiquette will make you more effective in these situations.[72] Search online for "dining etiquette" to find helpful videos on this topic. And remember that business meals are a forum for business. Don't discuss politics, religion, or any other topic that's likely to stir up emotions. Don't complain about work, don't ask deeply personal questions, avoid profanity, and be careful with humor—a joke that entertains some people could easily offend others.

Receptions are a common part of industry conferences and other business events, and they are a great opportunity to meet new people and renew old acquaintances. Although receptions can be good networking opportunities, don't press your business card on everyone or "pitch" yourself or your company to everyone you meet. Also, help people who are looking to join conversations. If you see someone standing near a group you are part of, pause the conversation and introduce yourself to help the newcomer feel included.

At receptions and other social events, help others feel welcome by introducing yourself and inviting them to join conversations.

ONLINE ETIQUETTE

Digital media seem to be a breeding ground for poor etiquette that can harm companies and careers. Whenever you represent your company online, in any medium, you must adhere to a high standard of etiquette and respect for others. Follow these guidelines:[73]

When you represent your company online, officially or unofficially, you must adhere to a high standard of etiquette and respect for others.

- **Avoid personal attacks.** The disconnected feel of online communication can cause even level-headed people to lose their tempers.
- **Stay focused on the original topic.** If you want to change the subject of an online conversation, start a new message or thread.
- **Follow basic expectations of spelling, punctuation, and capitalization.** Sending careless, acronym-filled messages undermines your credibility.
- **Use virus protection and keep it up to date.** Sending or posting a file that contains a computer virus puts others at risk.
- **Watch your language and keep your emotions under control.** A single indiscretion could haunt you forever.

Keep your cool online and use professional language.

- **Avoid multitasking while using messaging or other tools.** You might think you're saving time by doing a dozen things at once, but you're probably making the other person wait while you bounce back and forth between tasks.
- **Don't waste others' time with sloppy, confusing, or incomplete messages.** Doing so is disrespectful.
- **Never assume you have privacy.** Assume that anything you type will be stored forever, could be forwarded to other people, and might be read by your boss or the company's security staff.

Anything you say online could be seen by people far beyond your immediate audience, including your boss or your company's security staff.

- **Be careful of online commenting mechanisms.** For example, many blogs and websites let you use your Facebook login to comment on articles. If your Facebook profile includes your job title and company name, those could show up along with your comment.
- **Respect boundaries of time and virtual space.** For instance, don't use colleagues' or employees' personal social media accounts as a venue for business discussions, and don't assume people are available to discuss work matters around the clock, even if you do find them online in the middle of the night.

Respect personal and professional boundaries when using Facebook and other social networking tools.

TELEPHONE ETIQUETTE

Here are some important tips for using phones at work (for etiquette points specifically about mobile devices, see the next section):[74]

Basic courtesy on the phone makes communication more efficient and more pleasant for everyone involved.

- **Be conscious of how your voice sounds.** Don't speak in a monotone; vary your pitch and inflections so people know you're interested. Slow down when conversing with people whose native language isn't the same as yours.
- **Be courteous when you call someone.** Identify yourself and your organization, briefly describe why you're calling, and ask if you've called at a good time.
- **Convey a positive, professional attitude when you answer the phone.** Answer promptly and with a smile so that you sound welcoming. Identify yourself and your

company (some companies have specific instructions for what to say when you answer). If you need to forward a call, put the caller on hold first and call the next person yourself to verify that he or she is available.

- **End calls with courtesy and clarity.** Close in a friendly, positive manner and double-check all vital information, such as meeting times and dates.
- **Use your own voicemail features to help callers.** Record a brief, professional-sounding outgoing message for regular use. When you will be away or unable to answer the phone for an extended period, record a temporary greeting that tells callers when you will respond to their messages. If you don't check your messages regularly or at all, disable your voicemail or use your outgoing message to tell callers you don't check it. Letting voicemail messages pile up without answering them is extremely thoughtless.
- **Be considerate when leaving voicemail messages.** Unless voicemail is the only choice, consider leaving a message through other means, such as text messaging or email. If you do leave a voicemail message, make it as brief as possible. Leave your name, number, reason for calling, and times you can be reached.

If you never or rarely check your voicemail, disable it or record an outgoing message advising callers to reach you another way.

MOBILE DEVICE ETIQUETTE

Your mobile device habits send a signal about the degree of respect you have for those around you.

Like every other aspect of communication, your mobile device habits say a lot about how much respect you have for the people around you. Avoid these disrespectful choices:[75]

- Using obnoxious or inappropriate ringtones
- Failing to mute your phone during meetings or other situations where it will interrupt people
- Talking loudly in open offices or public places
- Talking on your phone right next to someone else
- Making or taking personal calls at work
- Invading privacy by using your phone's camera without permission
- Taking or making calls in restrooms and other inappropriate places
- Texting during meals or while someone is talking to you
- Allowing incoming calls to interrupt meetings or discussions
- Using voice recognition to the extent that it disrupts others

MOBILE APP

Locale can "geofence" your smartphone, automatically changing settings based on your location—such as activating silent mode when you arrive at your office.

Virtual assistants and other mobile phone voice features can annoy and disrupt the workplace and social settings if not used with respect for others.

Virtual, voice-activated assistants raise another new etiquette dilemma. From doing simple web searches to dictating entire memos, these systems may be convenient for users, but they can create distractions and annoyances for other people.[76] As with other public behaviors, think about the effect you have on others before using these technologies.

Note that expectations and policies regarding mobile device use vary widely from company to company. At one extreme, venture capitalist Ben Horowitz fines his employees if they even look at a mobile device while an entrepreneur is pitching a business plan because he considers it disrespectful to people making presentations.[77] Not all bosses are quite so strict, but make sure you understand the situation in your workplace.

COMMUNICATION CHALLENGE AT OpenText

You are a member of the Customer Experience Team at OpenText. Apply what you have learned in this chapter to these two challenges.

INDIVIDUAL CHALLENGE: Through direct communication with customers and customer experience reports, you collect feedback data, analyze it to extract key information, and forward this to the specific product teams, who then implement actions to address these issues. As you also provide your own input on how they could address the issues, by shaping behaviors, processes, and directions to better reflect the expectations and needs of customers, you are also helping shape each product team across the organization. The Customer Experience team holds routine meetings with other departments with these purposes in mind in a collaborative process, but a major aspect is presenting weaknesses and criticisms about a specific team as conveyed by the customer.

For one such meeting, you have received overwhelming reports about continued poor functionality and instability in one of the enterprise tools offered by the team you are about to meet with. In the past, you have felt that this department's team leader is often unreceptive to the criticisms in the data you present and dismisses you and your team's efforts. Their behavior is starting to affect your morale and self-confidence and cause problems for you in your own team, as their repeated

poor customer evaluations are being regarded as a sign of your ineffectiveness in conveying the Customer Experience team's hard work. How should you handle the situation?

TEAM CHALLENGE: Before you meet with other product teams to discuss their feedback, you must work with your colleagues in the Customer Experience team to collate, synthesize, and analyze the information from your various listening posts and produce a coherent summary report and series of suggestions for the relevant teams you will then meet. Though the overall projects are team efforts, each person is responsible for specific components, and this individual work is shared with your team to combine efforts and build the final deliverable for your meeting with other teams. As is common in collaborative efforts, you must consider what to include and what to exclude from the final product. You could carry out this selection process in the early stages, before the team has begun polishing their ideas, or each person could spend time honing their individual ideas and putting in the time to avoid prematurely omitting feedback that initially does not seem like much but later reveals itself to have more substance, which also runs the risk of all that time and work being scrapped at the final cutting table.

With a small team of fellow students, draft some brief guidelines for collaborative writers and presenters, conveying three points: (1) The brainstorming phase, where ideas are collated, and unanimous decisions are made on what will be pursued further; (2) the review stage, where ideas are somewhat fleshed out, further decisions are made on whether certain things are worth pursuing or not, and initial discussions are had on an overall theme for the presentation; (3) the stage of presentation planning, bringing together all fully researched arguments and forming a coherent and logically flowing presentation.

Key Terms

active listening Making a conscious effort to turn off filters and biases to truly hear and understand what someone is saying
collaboration Working together to meet complex challenges
constructive feedback Critique that focuses on the process and outcomes of communication, not on the people involved
content listening Listening to understand and retain the speaker's message
critical listening Listening to understand and evaluate the meaning of the speaker's message
cross-functional team A team that includes people from more than one department or functional area within the company
destructive feedback Criticism delivered with no guidance to stimulate improvement
empathic listening Listening to understand the speaker's feelings, needs, and wants so that you can appreciate his or her point of view
etiquette The expected norms of polite behavior in any situation
group dynamics Interactions and processes that take place among the members of a team
groupthink Situation in which peer pressure causes individual team members to withhold contrary or unpopular opinions
hidden agenda Private, counterproductive motives, such as a desire to take control of a group
minutes Written summary of the important information presented and the decisions made during a meeting
nonverbal communication Information sent and received, both intentionally and unintentionally, without using written or spoken language
norms Informal standards of conduct that group members share and that guide member behavior
parliamentary procedure A time-tested method for planning and running effective meetings; the best-known guide to this procedure is *Robert's Rules of Order*
participative management An effort to involve employees in a company's decision-making
task-oriented roles Productive team roles directed toward helping a team reach its goals
team A unit of two or more people who share a mission and the responsibility for working to achieve a common goal
team-maintenance roles Productive team roles directed toward helping everyone work well together
unified communication A single system of communication that integrates voice and video calling, voice and video conferencing, instant messaging, real-time collaboration software, and other capabilities
virtual meetings Meetings that take place online rather than in person
virtual team A team in which members work in at least two different locations and rely on technology to communicate and collaborate
wiki Special type of website that allows anyone with access to add new material and edit existing material

Summary of Learning Objectives

1 Describe the characteristics of effective teams, outline five steps for resolving team conflict, and offer advice on working in virtual teams. Effective teams tend to have (1) a shared sense of purpose and compatible values, (2) a clear and challenging goal, (3) a belief in the value of the team's efforts, (4) a well-balanced mix of participants, (5) a size that aligns well with the team's responsibilities, (6) an environment of psychological safety, (7) a willingness to put the team's needs first, and (8) open and honest communication.

To resolve conflict in teams

- Decide if the conflict is worth addressing
- Examine your own beliefs and behaviors to see if you are contributing to the problem
- Identify where the conflict truly originates
- Establish common ground
- Choose a strategy for resolving the differences (avoidance, accommodation, compromise, or collaboration)

To work successfully on a virtual team

- Keep the team as small as possible
- Use the best collaboration technology available
- Clarify the purpose of each tool
- Take special care with isolated members
- Don't rely solely on written communication

2 Offer guidelines for collaborative communication, explain what it means to give constructive feedback, and identify major collaboration technologies. Key guidelines for collaborative writing include

- Making sure the project goals are clear and agreed on
- Mapping out how the work will be done
- Structuring assignments so that each person can lend his or her greatest strengths
- Establishing frequent checkpoints
- Appreciating that people have different writing styles

Giving constructive feedback means focusing on the work and how it can be improved rather than on the person and any mistakes he or she may have made.

Major collaboration technologies include content management systems, wikis, shared online workspaces, social networks, workgroup messaging systems, and private networks (including intranets and extranets).

3 List the key steps needed to ensure productive meetings. The most important step in planning a meeting is to make sure that a meeting is necessary and is the best way to accomplish the given objective. If it is, proceed by identifying the purpose of the meeting, selecting the right mix of participants to accomplish the goal, choosing the venue and time carefully, and setting a clear agenda.

Once the meeting is under way, work to keep the discussion on track, follow agreed-on rules, encourage participation, participate actively yourself, don't interrupt, use mobile devices respectfully, and close the meeting effectively to make sure all decisions and action items are clearly understood.

4 Explain why listening is such a complex communication process, and describe three steps to becoming a better listener. Listening is vulnerable to all the potential barriers and breakdowns of communication in general plus several difficulties that are unique to listening: It is a real-time experience, spoken language is invisible, and listening requires the process of sound-to-language conversion. In addition, individuals can complicate listening through poor self-management, a lack of focus, ineffective listening style, internal and external barriers, and flawed recall.

5 Explain the importance of nonverbal communication, and identify six major categories of nonverbal expression. Nonverbal communication is important because nonverbal signals can strengthen, weaken, or even replace verbal messages. The major categories of nonverbal signals are facial expression, vocal characteristics, gestures and posture, personal appearance, touch, and the use of time and space.

6 Explain the importance of business etiquette, and identify five key areas in which good etiquette is essential. Attention to etiquette is essential to success in every form of business communication—so much so that etiquette is considered an important business skill. Poor etiquette can hinder team efforts, drain morale and productivity, drive away customers and investors, and limit your career potential. Five key areas in which good etiquette is essential are the workplace, social settings in which you represent your employer, online interactions in which you represent your employer, while using telephones, and when using mobile devices.

Test Your Knowledge

To review chapter content related to each question, refer to the indicated Learning Objective.

2-1. How can organizations and employees benefit from successful teamwork? [LO-1]
2-2. What is groupthink, and how can it affect an organization? [LO-1]
2-3. How can a shared workspace help teams in an organization increase their efficiency and output? [LO-2]
2-4. How does constructive feedback differ from destructive feedback? [LO-2]
2-5. What is the value of a well-prepared meeting agenda? [LO-3]
2-6. Why is listening such a challenging communication process? [LO-4]
2-7. How would the process of selective listening cause issues in communication? [LO-5]
2-8. What are the five elements of active listening? [LO-4]
2-9. What are the six major categories of nonverbal communication? [LO-5]
2-10. Why do mobile devices present unique etiquette challenges? [LO-6]

Apply Your Knowledge

To review chapter content related to each question, refer to the indicated Learning Objective.

2-11. If a team doesn't "storm" when it starts working, is this necessarily cause for concern? Why or why not? [LO-1]
2-12. You supervise a positive and enthusiastic new team leader who has sent an email to one of her team members and has copied you in it. The message is very short, has a demanding tone, and requires the completion of a rather complex piece of work within a very short deadline. You think the deadline will be very difficult to achieve, and knowing the recipient of message, you expect that the request might cause a very negative reaction, resulting in conflict within the team. Outline a course of action you could take to minimize a negative response and summarize appropriate developmental feedback for the new team leader. [LO-2]
2-13. You manage your company's software development lab, which has added several dozen new employees over the past year. One of the senior developers runs into you at lunch and starts to unload his frustrations about needing to get his own work done while being expected to mentor and train "a bunch of newbies." What style or styles of listening should you apply? Explain your answer. [LO-4]

2-14. Why do you think people are more likely to engage in rude behaviors during online communication than during in-person communication? [LO-6]

2-15. You're giving your first major presentation at your new job, and you notice at least half the people in the small conference room are looking at their mobile devices more than they are looking at you. How should you handle the situation? [LO-6]

Practice Your Skills

Message for Analysis

2-16. Planning Meetings [LO-3] Having just led a meeting, you want to ensure that, unlike many meetings, there is a definite follow-up process to ensure this one had value. Place the following actions in order of timing, providing a brief explanation for each decision.

- Send minutes and thanks to attending participants.
- Write a comprehensive set of minutes that highlight the main actions agreed upon during the meeting and who has responsibility for each action.
- Contact the stakeholders, share the minutes with them, and brief them on immediate and future outcomes.
- State the date, time, and place of the next meeting.
- Create entries in your calendar to check on interim progress on all agreed actions.
- Send an email to participants and stakeholders in the meeting to update them on progress since the meeting.
- Seek feedback from participants on how the meeting progressed and ask for their ideas on improving productivity in future meetings.
- Seek views on what items need to be included in the agenda for the next meeting.
- Brief, personally, any participants who could not attend the meeting if required to act.

Exercises

Each activity is labeled according to the primary skill or skills you will need to use. To review relevant chapter content, you can refer to the indicated Learning Objective. In some instances, supporting information will be found in another chapter, as indicated.

2-17. Collaboration: Working in Teams; Media Skills: Shared Workspace [LO-1], [LO-2] The corporate office, marketing, and finance departments of your company are scattered across three locations in the city. It is necessary to motivate and engage employees in an information exchange. Each department is requested to form a team and conduct a search on the Internet to find ways people can be motivated. Tabulate the findings of each team and narrow the list down to the 10 most popular motivational employee engagement activities that can be further discussed with the teams. Collaborate in a shared workspace with these departments on the details of these 10 activities.

2-18. Collaboration: Working in Teams; Media Skills: Shared Workspace [LO-1], [LO-2] The corporate office, marketing, and finance departments of your company are scattered across three locations in the city. There is a need to motivate and engage employees in an information exchange. Each department is requested to form a team and conduct a search on the Internet to find ways people could be motivated. Tabulate the findings of each team and narrow down to the 10 most popular motivational employee engagement activities that can be further discussed with the teams. Collaborate in a shared workspace with these departments on the details of these 10 best activities.

2-19. Collaboration: Collaborating on Writing Projects; Media Skills; Blogging [LO-2] You are asked to create a team of four people within an organization to develop an internal company blog. Your role is to create an environment that supports the proactive use of the blog by employees to create ideas, help sponsor a sense of belonging, and engage the employees of the business in its functioning. Choose a team of four colleagues following the guidelines in this chapter for selecting collaborators, and work together to develop a set of guiding principles you will all follow to produce engaging and vibrant content.

2-20. Collaboration: Using Collaboration Technologies [LO-2] In a team assigned by your instructor, use a free cloud-based collaborating writing tool such as Google Docs or Zoho (free for personal use) to collaborate on a set of directions that out-of-town visitors could use to reach a specific point on your campus, such as a stadium or dorm. The team should choose the location and the mode(s) of transportation involved. Be creative—brainstorm the best ways to guide first-time visitors to the selected location using all the media at your disposal.

2-21. Communication Etiquette: Etiquette in the Workplace; Participating in Meetings [LO-3], [LO-6] You have been asked by the chairperson of a group to observe a meeting she runs regularly.

She feels that it is unproductive and has asked you to make suggestions to improve its effectiveness. The meeting of twenty people starts at 16.45, fifteen minutes late because of late arrivals. The agenda is stated by the chair, who then allows individuals to talk after they raise a hand, but interruptions are frequent, and some participants talk to each other at any moment in the meeting. Some participants contribute nothing.

Write a brief, diplomatic email offering helpful advice to the chairperson.

2-22. Collaboration: Participating in Meetings [LO-3] With a classmate, attend a local community or campus meeting where you can observe a group discussion, vote, or take other group action. Take notes individually during the meeting and, afterward, work together to answer the following questions.

a. What is your evaluation of this meeting? In your answer, consider (1) the leader's ability to clearly articulate the meeting's goals, (2) the leader's ability to engage members in a meaningful discussion, (3) the group's dynamics, and (4) the group's listening skills.

b. How did group members make decisions? Did they vote? Did they reach decisions by consensus? Did

those with dissenting opinions get an opportunity to voice their objections?

c. How well did the individual participants listen? How could you tell?

d. Did any participants change their expressed views or their votes during the meeting? Why might that have happened?

e. Did you observe any of the communication barriers discussed in Chapter 1? Identify them.

f. Compare the notes you took during the meeting with those of your classmate. What differences do you notice? How do you account for these differences?

2-23. **Collaboration: Leading Meetings [LO-3], Chapter 3** Every month, each employee in your department is expected to give a brief oral presentation on the status of his or her project. However, your department has recently hired an employee who has a severe speech impediment that prevents people from understanding much of what he says. As the department manager, how will you resolve this dilemma? Please explain.

2-24. **Interpersonal Communication: Listening Actively [LO-4]** Your name has been proposed for the position of school representative for the next academic term. You have been told by management to improve your listening abilities. Identify six areas of improvement and rate yourself on a scale of 1 to 5, where 1 = always, 2 = frequently, 3 = sometimes, 4 = rarely, 5 = never. Analyze the findings and prepare a report of not more than 250 words that communicates areas of improvement where you feel you should begin immediately.

2-25. **Nonverbal Communication: Analyzing Nonverbal Signals [LO-5]** Select a business letter and envelope you have received at work or home. Analyze their appearance. What nonverbal messages do they send? Are these messages consistent with the content of the letter? If not, what could the sender have done to make the nonverbal communication consistent with the verbal communication? Summarize your findings in a post on your class blog or in an email message to your instructor.

2.26. **Communication Etiquette: Etiquette in the Workplace [LO-6]** As the regional manager of an international accounting firm, you place high priority on professional etiquette. Not only does it communicate respect to your clients, it also instills confidence in your firm by showing that you and your staff are aware of and able to meet the expectations of almost any audience. Earlier today you took four new employees to lunch with an important client. You've done this for years, and it's usually an upbeat experience for everyone, but today's lunch was a disaster. One of the employees made not one, not two, but three calls on his mobile phone during lunch. Another interrupted the client several times and even got into a mild argument. The third employee kept telling sarcastic jokes about politics, making everyone at the table uncomfortable. And the fourth showed up dressed like she was expecting to bale hay or work in a coal mine, not have a business lunch in a posh restaurant. You've already called the client to apologize, but now you need to coach these employees on proper business etiquette. Draft a brief memo to these employees, explaining why etiquette is so important to the company's success—and to their individual careers.

Expand Your Skills

Critique the Professionals

Celebrities can learn from successful businesses when it comes to managing their careers, but businesses can learn from successful celebrities, too—particularly when it comes to building communities online using social media. Locate three celebrities (musicians, actors, authors, or athletes) who have sizable fan bases on Facebook and analyze how they use the social network. Using whatever medium your instructor requests, write a brief analysis (no more than one page) of the lessons, positive or negative, that a business could learn from these celebrities. Be sure to cite specific elements from the Facebook pages you've chosen, and if you think any of the celebrities have made mistakes in their use of Facebook, describe those as well.

Sharpening Your Career Skills Online

Find a website, video, article, podcast, or presentation that offers advice on improving your active listening skills in business situations. Write a brief email message to your instructor, describing the item you found and summarizing the career skills information you learned from it.

Build Your Career

In the Build Your Career activity in Chapter 1, you started developing your job campaign by brainstorming what you would like to do in your career. Now it's time to tally up what you can offer an employer. If you haven't already, read "What Do You Have to Offer?" in the Prologue. Follow the guidance in that section and create two lists that you can review and update as you complete your college career and begin compiling your résumé, LinkedIn profile, and other employment documents. The first is a list of accomplishments that you are proud of and any academic, work, and general life experiences that were satisfying to you. The second is a list of the skills, knowledge, and personal characteristics that helped you reach those accomplishments or enjoy those experiences.

As you add to the lists over time, the first list will show a pattern of *what* you are capable of, and the second will provide the evidence of *how* you can do those things. Whenever you complete a college course, a volunteer project, or a work assignment, look back on the experience and see what you can add to one or both lists. When it's time to start applying and interviewing for your first post-college job, the lists will provide the evidence that you are ready to tackle the next exciting challenge in your career.

Five-Minute Guide to Better Business Meetings

Review these five points whenever you are thinking about hosting a business meeting.

00:01

What is the purpose of this meeting?

1. Do you want to exchange information, reach a decision, or collaborate on a problem or an opportunity?
2. Describe the best possible outcome of the meeting; use this description to plan the agenda.
3. If you can't describe the purpose of meeting in a single sentence, you need to refine your plan before you move forward.

00:02

Who should attend?

1. If you can control the attendee list, invite everyone who really needs to be involved, and don't invite anyone who doesn't.
2. Meetings with more than 10 or 12 people can become unmanageable if everyone is expected to participate in the discussion and decision-making.

00:03

Can you configure the meeting space?

1. Conference room layout is ideal for small meetings and working sessions, and it works for small presentations as well.
2. The U-shape is ideal for mid-sized meetings, working sessions, and presentations. It promotes speaker interaction and supports conversation among attendees.
3. Theater/auditorium style is best for large audiences, but it limits interaction and makes it difficult for audiences to work with documents or devices unless chairs include desk surfaces.
4. Classroom style, with attendees sitting at tables facing the speaker, is a good alternative to theater/auditorium style when you want to give participants more work surface.
5. The breakout session format with small teams around individual tables is good for working meetings or seminars in which you ask the audience to split into groups.

00:04

Prepare the agenda and plan ahead to record minutes

1. A good agenda answers three questions:
   a. What do we need to do in this meeting to accomplish our goals?
   b. What issues will be of greatest importance to all participants?
   c. What information must be available to discuss these issues?
2. Consider creating a simpler presentation agenda in addition to the detailed planning agenda.
3. Prepare any prestudy materials that attendees should read in order to be ready to participate.
4. Make provisions for someone to take notes and distribute minutes after the meeting.

00:05

Tips for planning and leading virtual meetings

1. Make sure the meeting has a well-defined task, so that it steadily moves toward a goal.
2. Provide prestudy materials so everyone is up to speed before the meeting starts.
3. Assign people to specific roles, such as a technical specialist to help with connectivity problems and someone to record the minutes.
4. If the participants don't know each other, introduce them or ask them to introduce themselves.
5. As you work through each agenda item, summarize what has been discussed and ask if anyone has questions or comments.
6. Periodically check in with each person, if feasible, to make sure there are no lingering questions or points of disagreement.

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